No Other Doctrine

By C. R. STAM

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By

CORNELIUS R. STAM

President, BEREAN BIBLE SOCIETY, *Chicago*

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Preface

Many who have read the book *Things That Differ*, *or The Fundamentals of Dispensationalism*, are not aware that it contains the subject matter of only one semester in a two-semester course on dispensationalism which I taught while dean of *Milwaukee Bible Institute.* The subject of the other semester was titled, *A Dispensational Survey of the Bible.*

It is perhaps needless to say that I have long had it on my heart to prepare this dispensational survey for publication in textbook form as a complementary volume to *Things That Differ.* This might well have been accomplished by now except for the urgent necessity of dealing Scripturally with those moral and doctrinal errors of the new evangelicalism which have already swept so many off their feet. Our situation is somewhat parallel to that outlined by St. Jude in the third verse of his epistle:

"Beloved, when I gave all diligence to write unto you of the common salvation, It was needful for me to write unto you, and exhort you that ye should earnestly contend for the faith which was once delivered unto the saints."

Jude had hoped to write to his brethren about a subject that would have delighted their hearts, but there was an emergency. False doctrine had been creeping in and it was "needful" to exhort them to "earnestly contend for the faith." Mark well, he did not say merely that it was needful for him to contend earnestly for the faith; it was needful rather for *him* to write them, exhorting them to contend earnestly for the faith.

This is the object of the present volume, though "the faith" in our case is the "one faith" of Eph. 4:5, the whole Bible in the light of the special revelation committed to Paul, or, if you will, *"the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the my*stery" (Rom. 16:25).

As our recent volume, *The Present Peril***,** was written to contend earnestly for the faith, this companion volume, we hope, will encourage *you* to contend earnestly for the faith. Its pages are taken largely from articles in the Berean *Searchlight* which the editor wrote with this particular purpose in view. It is titled *No Other Doctrine* after Paul's exhortation to Timothy to *"charge some that they teach no other doctrine*" (I Tim. 1:3).

While these pages have been penned by a fallible human author, and while the whole has now been published in defense of the faith, we trust that our discussion of the Word of God will at the same time bring encouragement and blessing to the hearts of readers whose sincere desire it is to "live soberly,

righteously and godly in this present age" (Tit. 2:12). As we send it forth we commend it to Cod, whose Spirit alone can apply it to hearts.

Cornelius R. Stam

CHICAGO, ILLINOIS
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Chapter I

THE FALL OF MAN
THE FALL OF ISRAEL
THE FALL OF BABYLON

Referring to the so-called "animal kingdom," G. K. Chesterton once said: "Only man can be ridiculous because only man can be dignified."

This is true. No one ever laughs when an animal stumbles and falls, but let a man do so and he makes himself an object of ridicule. This is so in the moral even more than in the physical realm. Man was made for dignity and glory and when he falls he makes a fool of himself.

THE FALL OF MAN

"*By one man's disobedience many were made sinners*" (Rom. 5:19).

Of man's original creation we read:

"SO GOD CREATED MAN IN HIS OWN IMAGE; IN THE IMAGE OF GOD CREATED HE HIM; MALE AND FEMALE CREATED HE THEM" (Gen. 1:27).

What a glorious being man must have been at that time! And commensurate with his original glory was his God-given abode and his God-given position:

"AND THE LORD GOD PLANTED A GARDEN EASTWARD IN EDEN; AND THERE HE PUT THE MAN WHOM HE HAD FORMED" (Gen. 2.8).

"AND GOD BLESSED THEM, AND GOD SAID UNTO THEM, BE FRUITFUL, AND MULTIPLY, AND REPLENISH THE EARTH, AND SUBDUE IT; AND HAVE DOMINION OVER THE FISH OF THE SEA, AND OVER THE FOWL OF THE AIR, AND OVER EVERY LIVING THING THAT MOVETH UPON THE EARTH" (Gen. 1:28).

In the beautiful garden of Eden, with all its luscious fruits, God had, however, placed one tree of which man was not to partake. This tree stood as a symbol of the distinction between God and man, a constant reminder that He was the Creator and man the creature, He the Sovereign and man the subject, and that man's life and happiness depended upon a recognition of this relationship.

With man's rebellion against this order, therefore, all was suddenly changed. The two who had enjoyed such blessed fellowship with God in the beauty of the garden of Eden were suddenly overtaken by a sense of guilt and fear and shame. In a pathetic attempt to cover their nakedness and make themselves acceptable to God, *"they sewed fig leaves together, and made themselves aprons"* (Gen. 3:7). But the futility of their effort is seen in the fact that upon hearing the voice of God in the garden they "hid themselves" from His presence.

"And the Lord God called unto Adam, and said unto him, WHERE ART THOU?

"And he said, I heard thy voice in the garden, and I WAS AFRAID, BECAUSE I WAS NAKED; AND I HID MYSELF" (Gen. 3:9,20).

Already man had become a fallen creature, cursed by sin and "alienated from the life of God." And with his fall the whole terrestrial creation was cursed and ruined and made subject to "the bondage of corruption," as we see it today.

"For we know that the whole creation groaneth and travaileth in pain together until now" (Rom. 8,22).

Modern evolution, of course, denies the Bible account of the fall and has much to say about "the *ascent* of man," but evolution fails to account for, indeed, assiduously evades, that which lies at the very root of all man's troubles: *sin*. It fails to explain adequately why man finds himself weak, poor, miserable, distressed, corrupt, perishing, and it fails to explain why he is so utterly helpless to lift himself from this state. It fails to explain his inherent sense of blame-worthiness; indeed insists he has no cause for a "guilt complex."

Every man feels within himself a disorder, a positive *dis*location of things, which science - certainly the *theory* of evolution - is unable to explain. Only the Bible account of the fall explains it and shows how all man's trouble and distress arise from his own *nature*, which is fallen and corrupt.

". . . BY ONE MAN SIN ENTERED INTO THE WORLD, AND DEATH BY SIN; AND SO DEATH PASSED UPON ALL MEN, FOR THAT ALL HAVE SINNED" (Rom. 5:12).

It is most important for the unsaved to learn this lesson; to learn that it is not merely our sins, but our *sin* that makes us unfit for the presence of God; not merely our deeds but our *nature*; not merely what we have done, but what we *would* do because we are *essentially* sinful as the children of Adam.

Nor does the fact that we were *born* sinners in any way diminish our guilt. Indeed, it emphasizes it, for the above passage explains that "death passed upon all men," not merely because Adam sinned, but because "*all* have sinned," i.e., *in Adam*. By nature we are as much part of Adam as the leaf is to the branch and the branch to the tree. When Adam sinned, we sinned. We were *in* Adam; we have *come from* Adam, and thus partake of his fallen, sinful nature.

Before man's creation God Said: "Let us make man in our image, after our likeness," but after the fall we read that Adam "begat a son in his *own* likeness, after *his* image" (Gen. 1:26, cf. 5:3).

Thus the Galilean shepherds, for example, were sore afraid" when *"the glory of the Lord shone round about them*!" (Luke 2:9), and we should be "sore afraid" under similar circumstances, simply because "*all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God"* (Rom. 3:23).

At man's very best his general condition is still most aptly described by the word *fallen*. Try as he will he cannot lift himself from his depraved and sinful condition, nor from its results, and all his efforts to do so are but those of a man trying to "lift himself by his bootstraps."

Thank God, we may be delivered from the guilt and condemnation of sin and from the death and corruption it has brought, by faith in Christ, who "died for our sins" and was "made a curse for us" (I Cor. 15:3; Gal 3:13). By faith we may begin to enjoy this deliverance even now, Yet its fulness is still future, for while *in Christ* the simplest believer is "complete" (Col. 2:10), fully justified (Rom. 3:24; 8:33,34) and already seated in the heavenlies (Eph. 2:4-6), nevertheless *"we through the Spirit WAIT for the hope of [perfect personal] righteousness by faith"* (Gal. 5:5) and *"look for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ, who shall change our vile body,*[1] *that it may be fashioned like unto His glorious body, according to the working whereby He is able even to subdue all things unto Himself"* (Phil. 3:20,21).

But let us now proceed from the fall of the race to the fall of a nation.

THE FALL OF ISRAEL

"The fall of them . . . the riches of the world" (Rom. 11:12)

The children of Abraham were, of course, originally the children of Adam, and as such, sinners by nature and practice. Abraham and his seed had not been chosen from among the Gentiles because they were better than they, but

[1] Or, "body of humiliation."

because God, in His sovereign grace, had planned to bless all nations through them.

The Mosaic law was given to emphasize this fact, for while it was appropriate and essential that God's favored people should possess a clear knowledge of His will, it was the written law that laid bare their inherent sinfulness. Thus we read that "by *the law is the knowledge of sin*" and that *"the law entered that the offense might abound"* (Rom. 3:20; 5:20).

Some of the people of Israel, like David, humbly acknowledged their sinful condition and the impotence of mere sacrifices to take away their sins, looking in faith to God for pardon and for help to live pleasing in His sight. These were the children of Abraham in the *full* sense of the word and, like him, were justified by faith.

Others among the favored People, however, and indeed the nation as a whole, remained unconvicted of their sin. When John the Baptist called upon them to repent in view of Messiah's coming, he was beheaded by the wicked and licentious "king of Israel." When Christ took up the same call, He was crucified. And when the apostles and disciples called upon Israel to repent and accept the *risen*, *ascended* Messiah, they were threatened and Persecuted and Stephen was stoned to death.

Even as Paul went forth preaching "to the Jew first," offering Christ as Israel's only hope, his message was rejected all the way from Jerusalem to Rome, where he said: *"For the hope of Israel I am bound with this chain*" (Acts 28:20).

Thus the apostle had to write:

"But Israel, which followed after the law of righteousness, hath not attained to the law of righteousness.

"Wherefore? Because they sought it not by faith, but as *It* were by the works of the law.[2] For they stumbled at that stumbling stone" (Rom. 9:31,32).

"Brethren, my heart's desire and prayer to God for Israel is, that they might be saved.

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[2] Note here the distinction between believing obedience to the law, because it was recognized as God's Word ("the Obedience of faith") and the performance of law works as a way of establishing one's own righteousness. Israel as a nation fell into the latter category.

"For I bear them record that they have a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge.

"FOR THEY BEING IGNORANT OF GOD'S RIGHTEOUSNESS, AND GOING ABOUT TO ESTABLISH THEIR OWN RIGHTEOUSNESS, HAVE NOT SUBMITTED THEMSELVES UNTO THE RIGHTEOUSNESS OF GOD.

"FOR CHRIST IS THE END OF THE LAW FOR RIGHTEOUSNESS TO EVERY ONE THAT BELIEVETH" (Rom. 20:1-4).

"What then? Israel hath not obtained that which he seeketh for; but the election hath obtained it, and the rest were blinded" (Rom. 11:7).

Thus the favored nation fell, as we read in Romans 11**,** and was temporarily cast away and scattered,[3] as the Gentiles had been scattered more than two thousand years previous. Who can observe Israel and fail to see this?

But *why* did Israel fall? Simply because the children of Israel were the children of Adam too. God had given them the law, not to help them to be good, but to show them that they, along with the Gentiles, were by nature bad. He had *made* a difference in order to prove that essentially there is no difference and that they might seek forgiveness as poor sinners. Nowhere is this more clearly stated than in Rom. 3:19.

"Now we know that what things soever the law saith, It saith to them who are under the law [Israel]; THAT EVERY MOUTH MAY BE STOPPED, AND ALL THE WORLD MAY BECOME GUILTY BEFORE GOD."

But the people of Israel, as a nation, had not learned the lesson. They would not close their mouths. They said, in effect: "We are not through yet," and continued to go about to "establish their own righteousness."

Thus it was that Israel fell from the place of privilege and favor. God allowed them to fall in order to demonstrate historically the lesson they had refused to learn by the law: that "there *is* no difference"; that not even *they* were better than others; that *all* mankind is fallen and that *all* need a Savior. And thus too God would show the riches of His grace. Israel's fall had conclusively demonstrated man's utter ruin,

"But where sin abounded, grace did much more abound" (Rom. 5:20).

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[3] The Old Testament saints who truly sought God in faith will have their part in the millennial kingdom, but this will not take place until Israel turns to Christ (see Rom. 11:15,25,26).

"For God hath concluded them all In unbelief, that He might have mercy upon all" (Rom. 12:32).

"And that He might reconcile both [Jews and Gentiles] unto God in one body by the cross, having slain the enmity thereby" (Eph. 2: 16).

THE FALL OF BABYLON

***"In one hour is thy judgment come"* (Rev. 18:10).**

With the casting away of Israel God began to reconcile both Jews and Gentiles to Himself on equal terms, "*to make in Himself of twain ONE NEW MAN,"* called*: "the Body of Christ"* (Eph. 2:15; 1 Cor. 12:13,27).

Yet here again the depravity of man is exposed. The *true* Church of this dispensation, the Body of Christ, is of course composed of all true believers, and whatever their failures, they are justified through the blood of Christ and will some day be glorified and made like Him (Rom. 8:30). But the *professing* Church is what *men* see. In it, thank God, there are many who are truly saved, but as a whole it is apostate and, after the Lord has come to take His own away, it will be entirely so.

The Word of God has much to say about Babylon. Ancient Babylon was the fountainhead of idolatry and will appear again in Babylon of the future, described so fully in Rev. 17 and 18.

Consistently Babylon is set in juxtaposition to Jerusalem, which represents the worship of the true God. As the old Babylon stands over against the old Jerusalem, so the future Babylon stands over against the new Jerusalem. One is called "*the holy city*," the other "the *mother of* ... *abominations of the earth*" (Rev. 17:5). One is called "*a bride*," the other "*a harlot*" and "*the mother of harlots"* (Rev. 21:2; 17:5). One stands for truth and purity, the other for infidelity and idolatry.

Whatever we still have to learn about the Babylon of the future - and there is much - it seems clear that it represents what will be left of Christendom and the professing Church after the members of the Body of Christ have been caught away.

We must not overlook the fact that the professing Church has failed as signally as Israel once did and that she will be given up to judgment as Israel once was. Indeed, if there is any indication that the coming of the Lord for His own may be very near it is *the present condition of the professing Church.*

We remember the inspired words of Paul that before the day of the Lord comes many professing believers "*will not endure sound doctrine; but after their*

own lusts [desires] shall they heap to themselves teachers, having itching ears: and they shall turn away their ears from the truth, and shall be turned unto fables [stories]" (II Tim. 4:3,4).

What an apt description of just what is taking place in the professing Church today! If ever there was a falling away from *the truth* it is now. "Forget doctrine and preach Jesus!" they cry. Even true but uninstructed believers join the chorus. The study and understanding of God's Holy Word means less and less to them as they barter it for a shallow, frivolous evangelism that has no higher aim than getting "decisions for Christ," giving its hearers little or no *understanding* of the great truths associated with justification by faith in Christ or identification with Him; that preaches a Christ who still remains a mystical Being to those who have "decided" for Him. Or, perhaps, they barter a knowledge of the written Word for human tradition, dead creeds and a withered, formal religion, hoping that its "ordinances" will do something for them.

That the professing Church of this dispensation has dismally failed is evident from the fact that she has been in the world for nineteen centuries, yet has left millions upon millions of her fellowman without the gospel; indeed has herself perverted the gospel. Nor has the true Church, within the professing Church, been blameless here, for in this, the 20th Century, the great majority of fundamentalist believers are still working - though half-heartedly - under the wrong commission, arguing all the while about the problems associated with the legalism, the baptismal salvation and the miraculous signs of that commission!

Thank God that salvation today is by grace through faith, apart from works, as the Pauline epistles teach us, otherwise scarcely any one would be saved, but the whole situation is so confused that before it goes too far the Lord will come to call His own to Himself and will leave the rest to judgment.

Make no mistake, the professing Church of today will culminate in the Babylon of tomorrow. Certainly the utter confusion, the mixture of formality with fanaticism, of tradition with manworship, of dogma with superstition, is not a far cry from what we know of Babylonianism, and when the Lord comes for His own the world will be fully ripe for this false religion that will prevail under the name of Christianity.

"And then shall that Wicked [one] be revealed ... Even him, whose coming is after the working of Satan with all power and signs and lying wonders,

"And with all deceivableness of unrighteousness in them that perish; BECAUSE THEY RECEIVED NOT THE LOVE OF THE TRUTH, THAT THEY MIGHT BE SAVED.

"AND FOR THIS CAUSE GOD SHALL SEND THEM STRONG DELUSION, THAT THEY SHOULD BELIEVE A LIE;

"THAT THEY ALL MIGHT BE DAMNED [CONDEMNED] WHO BELIEVED NOT THE TRUTH, BUT HAD PLEASURE IN UNRIGHTEOUSNESS" (II Thes. 2:8-12).

"That wicked one" referred to here is, of course, the "man of sin" of Verse 3, the coming Antichrist,

"Who opposeth and exalteth himself above all that is called God, or that Is worshipped; so that he as God sitteth In the temple of God, showing himself that he Is God" (Ver. 4).

Thus, after true believers are caught up to be with Christ at the close of the present dispensation of grace, the religion of this world will be headed up in Antichrist and what remains of the professing Church will be Babylon, the religious confusion of tongues, united only in rejecting and denying the *truth.*

As to Antichrist, Paul, by the Spirit, calls him "the son of *perdition."*

". . . **whom the Lord shall consume with the spirit of His mouth, and shall destroy with the brightness of His coming" (II Thes. 2:8).**

And Babylon will suffer the same judgment, for John, by the Spirit, prophesies:

". . . **BABYLON THE GREAT IS FALLEN, IS FALLEN, AND IS BECOME THE HABITATION OF DEVILS, AND THE HOLD OF EVERY FOUL SPIRIT. AND A CAGE OF EVERY UNCLEAN AND HATEFUL BIRD" (Rev. 18:2).**

And "the kings of the earth" and "the merchants of the earth" shall lament her fall, saying:

"ALAS, ALAS, THAT GREAT CITY BABYLON, THAT MIGHTY CITY! FOR IN ONE HOUR IS THY JUDGMENT COME" (Rev. 18:10).

Thus will God judge the organized religion of that day - that which remains of the professing Church of *our* day.

As God judged Adam and Eve for their rebellion; as He judged Israel for her apostasy, so will He finally judge the professing Church of Christ.

In the light of all this we beg our readers not place their trust in the Church or in man. The best of men are only men at the very best - the offspring of fallen Adam - and the *professing Church* is doomed to certain judgment.

Let us turn from fallen, failing man; even from his religious institutions, to place our trust in that blessed Book, the Word of God. Let us base our beliefs, not on the teachings of a confused and divided religious organization but on the teachings of the eternal Word of God - and that "rightly divided." Let us regulate our lives and determine our practices, not by Church creeds, nor by popular movements, but by God's revealed will for us today, as outlined for us in the Epistles of Paul.

Chapter II

IN EARTHEN VESSELS

“We have this treasure In earthen vessels, that the excellency of the power may be of God, and not of us."

- II Cor. 4:7.

FAILING CHRISTIAN LEADERS

"Some indeed preach Christ even of envy and strife, and some also of good will.

"The one preach Christ of contention, not sincerely, supposing to add affliction to my bonds:

"But the other of love, knowing that I am set for the defense of the gospel" (Phil. 2:15-17).

Have you been disappointed in your pastor or the officers of your church or perhaps in Christian leaders in general? Have you placed great faith in some spiritual leader only to be disillusioned and to find out that your faith has been misplaced? Have you observed the growing popularity of some evangelist or Bible teacher whom you know to be insincere, while noting that another, whose fidelity and sincerity are beyond question, seems to get nowhere?

Many unsaved people have begun attending church and have quit altogether because of such things. And many truly saved people have been so sorely disillusioned by the failures they have observed in Christian leaders that their own spiritual experience has been adversely affected.

How it helps, in such situations, to be able to “rightly divide the Word of truth," and to enjoy *"the full assurance of understanding*," that comes with *"the full knowledge [Gr., epignosis] of the mystery*"! (Col. 2:2).

WHEN SPIRITUAL LEADERS DID NOT FAIL

There was a time in history - a short time - when spiritual leaders did *not* fail.

At Pentecost, we read, *"they were all filled with the Holy Spirit"* (Acts 2:4).

This was not because the disciples were all so godly, or devoted. It was not because they had prayed earnestly enough or had exercised the necessary

faith. It was simply because "*the day of Pentecost was fully come*." The time had come for the fulfillment of God's *promise*, and apart from any spiritual virtue in themselves, *"they were all filled with the Holy Spirit*," from the least of them to the greatest of them.

Pentecost introduced an era which was an earnest of the kingdom to come. Filled with the Spirit, and completely under His control, the followers of Christ not only possessed the power to speak with tongues and work miracles, but also to live lives that truly honored Christ. We search the record in vain for any failure, blunder or sin with which they might be charged. Indeed, they were all united in heart and soul and lived spontaneously for one another. Though the company soon came to number well over five thousand, the record says of them:

"And the multitude of them that believed were of one heart and of one soul: neither said any of them that ought of the things which he possessed was his own; but they had all things common" (Acts 4:32).

A DISPENSATIONAL CHANGE

Pentecost must have been a refreshing experience; a blessed foretaste of the kingdom to come! But when Israel rejected the glorious King and His kingdom, a change in dispensation took place. The Pentecostal order passed away and *"this present evil age"* set in (Gal. 1:4). *"But where sin abounded*, *grace did much more abound*" (Rom. 5:20) and God's special apostle for *this* age was not one of the twelve, but the chief of sinners, saved by grace and sent forth to proclaim *"the gospel [good news] of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24).

During this "evil age," and under this "dispensation of the grace of God," all believers are not "filled with the Spirit" - not even all Christian leaders. The Spirit is rather given to us by *grace,* so that we may appropriate His help by *faith*, but here we all are prone to fail.[4]

Thus it is that only twelve years after Pentecost, we find believers no longer living together in perfect harmony. In fact, even the most godly and sincere among them found it impossible to live in unmarred fellowship with all who shared their faith in Christ.

In Acts 15 Paul and Barnabas had "*no small dissension and disputation*" with the Judaizers from Judaea. At the great Jerusalem council, which resulted from this, there were deep undercurrents of disagreement and ill feeling, as "the Pharisees which believed" pressed their arguments for demanding circumcision and law observance of the Gentile believers in general and of Titus in particular (Acts 15:5; Gal. 2:3). Indeed there were even some *"false brethren*" who had

[4] See the author's book, *True Spirituality*.

been secretly brought in, as Paul says, *"to spy out our liberty, which we have in Christ Jesus, that they might bring us into bondage"* (Gal. 2:4). Paul was quite aware of this, and *"gave place by subjection, no, not for an hour*" (Gal. 2:5). And as we read the record we are disappointed to find that only after "there had been much disputing" (Acts 15:7) did Peter rise to give the testimony that might have rendered much of the disputation unnecessary.

What a scene of party spirit and intrigue among brethren, believers in Christ! What tensions there must have been among them! And there have been many similar conventions among believers since.

Years later, in the record of Scripture, we find conditions still the same. The Apostle Paul has now proclaimed the message of grace far and wide and churches have been established from Antioch to Rome, all based on the great revelation of the glorified Lord to Paul - "*the dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:2).

Were the believers in these assemblies "all filled with the Holy Spirit"? Far from it! There were many grave failures among them: bickering, party spirit, boasting, moral laxity, a desire to return to the law, doctrinal heresy and what not. And now that Paul was in prison some of those would-be leaders who not hitherto dared to become too bold began to assert themselves.

Thank God, there were some godly, but timid men who, touched by Paul's imprisonment, were now emboldened to preach the Word without fear. These carried on the apostle's work out of "good will" and "love," recognizing his stand "for the defense of the gospel" (Phil. 1:14-17). But there were others who, though indeed "brethren in the Lord" (Ver. 14), actually preached Christ "even of envy and strife" (Ver. 15). They were jealous of the apostle's spiritual power and success, and this was now their chance to shine. Some were even insincere in their preaching, secretly pleased at Paul's imprisonment and their own newfound freedom, and supposing that their "success" was adding affliction to his bonds. But they were wrong, very wrong, in presuming that the apostle was as petty, spiritually, as they. Summing up the whole situation, this great and humble man of God wrote:

"What then? Notwithstanding every way, whether in pretense, or in truth, CHRIST IS PREACHED; AND I THEREIN DO REJOICE, YEA, AND WILL REJOICE" (Phil. 1:18).

His great desire had been that Christ might be more widely and diligently proclaimed. All right, this was now being done. He was not about to find fault with God for the instruments He was pleased to use to accomplish this end. His "*yea, and will rejoice*," seems to indicate that he was determined to crush any feelings of envy or self-interest.

SPIRITUAL LESSONS TO LEARN

We believe that the Apostle Paul wrote to the Philippian believers about these things - indeed we believe that the Spirit *inspired* him to write them, for several important reasons.

First, he would have us understand clearly the character of the dispensation under which we are living. In Rom. 5:20 it is written:

"Moreover the law entered, that the offense might abound. BUT WHERE SIN ABOUNDED, GRACE DID MUCH MORE ABOUND."

Thus in *"this present evil age"* we are living under "*the dispensation of the grace of God."*

God is not saving good people, nor even people who will repent and "do works meet for repentance." Rather, He is saving poor sinners who will come to Him with all their sin. He does not want us to serve Him to *gain* anything. He wants us to serve Him out of love and gratitude for all He has so freely done for us.

Similarly, He does not use only those who are filled with the Holy Spirit. Service now is on the basis of grace, and *all* who serve Him are poor, failing creatures at best. More than that: In His sovereign grace He may even use some who are insincere in their motives to proclaim the Word, as well as some who are deeply in earnest. We must never complain of this, for this is His right. But even apart from this there is no basis for complaint, for He has made it abundantly clear that only those who serve Him in sincerity and truth will be rewarded "at that day." Thus, while we cannot conscientiously go along with all that other Christians do, their failures should not embitter us.

Secondly, if we clearly understand the character of this present dispensation, we will not so soon be discouraged in our ministry for Christ.

Look at the way believers lived together during the Pentecostal era and you are apt to exclaim: "*Why can't we live that way today? Let's get back to Pentecost*." But look at the way believers lived together after the raising up of Paul, even among his beloved Philippians, and you will say: "It is no different today." This is because the believers at Pentecost were *all* filled with the Spirit in fulfillment of God's promise, while today He has in grace committed His message to *failing* men and women, who indeed possess the Spirit, but often grieve Him.

"But we have this treasure in earthen vessels,[5] THAT THE EXCELLENCY OF THE POWER MAY BE OF GOD, AND NOT OF US" (II Cor. 4:7).

Finally, these things have been recorded for the spiritual effect they should have upon us. The fact that Paul could rejoice that *Christ* was proclaimed by even those who were envious of him and insincere in their motives, surely must have made a great impression upon the divided Philippians-and it should upon us. The message is clear: No matter what the failures of others, *you* see that *you* are true and faithful. This writer's mother consistently impressed upon her children this precept: "Always be very exacting with yourself and very understanding with others."

It is in view of the character of the dispensation of grace that the apostle writes to the believers of his day**,** rejoicing in *their "faith in Christ Jesus, and love unto all the saints"* (Eph. 1:15; Col. 1:4). Let us never make this to read: "*love* for Christ Jesus, and *faith* in all the saints," for if we place our faith in the saints we will surely be disillusioned, and as to our love for Christ, this is always so far short of its appropriate measure that the apostle never once even mentions it in any of his epistles. He can only marvel and revel in the blessed One *"who loved me and gave Himself for me*" (Gal. 2:20).

[5] Vessels that are easily cracked and broken.

Chapter III

THE WISDOM OF THIS WORLD

“Where Is the wise? Where is the scribe? Where is the disputer of this world? Hath not God made foolish the wisdom of this world?"

- I Cor. 1:20.

This challenge was hurled at the intellectual world of nineteen hundred years ago, so famous for its philosophy, literature and art. Nor are these the words of one who himself lacked the benefits of higher learning. Rather, they flowed from the pen of one of the most learned men, one of the greatest thinkers of all time, *the Apostle Paul*. More than this, they are found in that Book of books, *the Bible,* which has withstood, not barely but magnificently, all the attacks of a thousand critics through centuries of time.

Many believers have a complex about their Christian convictions and speak of them apologetically when face to face with "the wise of this world." There are two passages of Scripture they are perhaps prone to forget. These are I Cor. 3:19 and Prov. 9:10:

"The wisdom of this world is foolishness with God."

"The fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom."

Actually, the "intellectuals" in any age are those who assent to the theories of those who agree with each other that they are intellectual. Dissent from them and you have automatically branded yourself an illiterate!

But has not the world made great progress, intellectually, since Paul's day? Is this not evident on every hand?

Of course! For one thing, our physicists have taught us how to kill each other much faster now. Moscow, London or Washington could be wiped out in a few minutes, and this is a considerable saving in time!

And think what has been accomplished in the field of electronics! We can now keep intelligent people glued to their TV sets for hours on end, their eyes riveted to shows which are not always wholesome, but sometimes at least entertaining and occasionally even informative. And think of the many time-saving devices in our homes! We are all saving so much time that we cannot even be hospitable to each other and our mental institutions are over-crowded with patients who have collapsed from enjoying all this leisure time.

Then consider our achievements in transportation! Our thoroughfares are crowded with automobiles whose drivers are getting jangled nerves in traffic jams and choking in the deadly carbon monoxide fumes, or else racing at high speeds, which is great fun until suddenly some object looms up ahead as if from nowhere. And the airplane! This is really something! We can now fly through the air with so much noise and commotion that innocent people for miles around our larger airports are kept awake nights. Of course, the minority should be willing to suffer cheerfully for the majority and it *is* important that great numbers of people get places *fast, fast, fast.*

But all this is nothing compared with what is going on in outer space. We now have all sorts of things orbiting around out there - and it's not all debris. It includes some very sensitive instruments, serving us faithfully from day to day. Indeed, men from our earth have actually landed on the moon and have brought some of its rocks and dust back with them. Soon, maybe, we will have people from beautiful New England, or the breath-taking Rockies, or the lovely shores of Oregon, living on its barren wastes. Wonderful prospect! And we can always get the necessary billions from the taxpayers.

But the best of it is that while we aspire to reach the moon, and even Mars, we've got a Great Society going on earth; a Society whose wild pagan music has all but replaced the beautiful melodies and harmonies of the classics, and whose twisted "art" reflects the bewildered confusion of our times; a Society in which children and young people are corrupted, women are robbed and raped, and men, women *and* children are murdered in the streets.

Oh, it's wonderful! The young people demonstrating at our universities for the right to use filthy language if they want to, and demanding a greater voice in running our institutions of learning; the minority groups marching to protest their various grievances, the rioting and bloodshed, the burning and looting! And meantime, ever so quietly, our most sophisticated mob syndicates are running fine motels and other business organizations - *and* pouring an ever-increasing flow of narcotics, pornographic literature, etc., into our enlightened community, judges and juries doing what they can to favor the criminals and, should any of them land behind prison bars, the parole boards are there to help get them released as soon as possible, so that our happy society may benefit from their experience and our mental and penal institutions may be further enlarged. Surely we've never had it so good.

THE WORLD AND THE BELIEVER

In discussing the world and its "achievements" we have been using the pronoun "we" because we are *in* the world and in that sense part of it. We are mindful, however, of our Lord's prayer concerning His disciples:

"They are not of the world, even as I am not of the world.

"Sanctify them [Lit., "Set them apart"] through Thy truth: Thy Word is truth" (John 17:16,17).

God's people in every age have indeed been set apart from the world about them by their faith in His Word. Hence, in a very important sense it must be said of them: "*They are not of the world."* With this in mind, let us see whether this world is actually so wise where the most vital matters are concerned.

WHAT ABOUT CHRIST?

Is He alive - *actually*, *physically?* The Scriptures declare in the clearest, most emphatic language that He is; that after His resurrection He spent forty days with His disciples, after which the disciples went everywhere proclaiming His resurrection. The Apostle Paul declared:

". . . **He was seen of above five hundred brethren at once; of whom the greater part remain unto this present[6] ... And last of all he was seen of me also . . ." (I Cor. 15:6,8).**

This highly-educated and intellectual man paid the price to proclaim the resurrection even to the Lord's bitterest enemies, who dared not permit themselves to believe that He was alive again. And Luke, that painstaking gatherer of evidence, declares that our Lord *"showed Himself alive after His passion by many infallible proofs"* (Acts 1:3).

Is all this testimony false? The world doubts that Christ is alive, but cannot be certain.

At Easter time, to be sure, apostate religious leaders cry: "He lives! They crucified Him, but the good He did lives on. His influence is felt on every hand." But their language betrays their *un*belief in His resurrection from the dead. The "Easter story" is rather a sort of religious myth which must be accepted by "faith." This on the "intelligent" basis that actual resurrection from the dead is, of course, impossible.

But true faith cannot rest upon a myth. Whether or not Christ *actually* arose from the dead is a subject of the profoundest importance to mankind - for two reasons:

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[6] Implying that his statement could easily be verified.

1. Christ was nailed to a cross *by men in this world*, and left there to die in agony and disgrace. Though secular history acclaims Him as a good man, and sacred history as the God man, no move has ever been made by mankind, or any segment of mankind, to repudiate this awful deed.

2. The Scriptures plainly declare that men will one day stand before Him as their Judge.

"[God] hath appointed a day, in the which He will judge the world In righteousness by that man whom He hath ordained; whereof He hath given assurance unto all men, In that He hath raised Him from the dead" (Acts 27:31; cf. John 5:22,27, Acts 10:42, etc.).

The question of our Lord's resurrection from the dead, then, is of the gravest importance to every man, yet the great thinkers of this unbelieving world are in the dark about it. Their intellects doubt what the Scriptures affirm, but they do not *know*; they cannot be *certain*. They can only wonder and worry.

But we believers are not left in any such uncertainty. We see the sublime logic of God's message about Christ. In Christ's resurrection we see the only tangible evidence that our sins have been paid for and the sin question justly settled. In Christ's resurrection we see also the guarantee of our own, and exclaim with the Apostle Peter:

"Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who, according to His abundant mercy, hath begotten us again unto a living hope by the resurrection of Jesus Christ from the dead" (I Pet. 1:3).

We believers see the validity of Paul's declaration:

"If Christ be not risen, then is our preaching vain, and your faith is also vain. Yea, and we are found false witnesses of God.... And if Christ be not raised ... ye are yet In your sins" (I Cor. 15:14-17).

To those "intellectuals" who deny the possibility of bodily resurrection, we ask with Paul:

"Why should it be thought a thing incredible with you that should raise the dead?" (Acts 26:8).

Why should He who *gave* life in the first place be unable to *restore* it? Indeed, we are surrounded with overwhelming evidence of God's resurrection power; evidence which caused Paul to answer unbelievers with the withering reply:

"Thou fool! That which thou sowest is not quickened [brought to life] EXCEPT IT DIE" (I Cor. 25:36; cf. John 12:24).

Actually, we believers once had to overcome a natural unbelief in the resurrection, but now, in the words of Paul: *"Through faith we understand*." It was only when we *believed* God's Word about the risen, living Christ that we came to know Him and love Him, along with millions of others. It is not mere intellectual assent, but *faith* that honors God. Thus the Apostle Paul calls God's Word as to Christ and the resurrection: *"the word of faith which we preach*:

"That if thou shalt confess with thy mouth Jesus as Lord, and shalt believe in thine heart that God hath raised Him from the dead, thou shalt be saved" (Rom. 10:9).

WHAT ABOUT THE NATIONS?

How the worldly-wise smile at us believers when we insist that there is no hope of lasting peace in this world apart from the personal return of Christ!

But do we not have greater reason to smile at their futile attempts to bring about lasting peace? Is it not pure naiveté on their part to suppose that they can change human nature and make this world permanently a nice place to live in?

For centuries the world's leaders have been gathering around tables composing peace pacts, which they first sign amid solemn ceremonies and then, later, tear up as so many worthless scraps of paper. They never give up, though, for even as the collective ship of state goes down they stand on the wreck, still proclaiming their bright visions of "lasting peace and prosperity," perhaps through the "United" Nations.

Actually they do not *know* what will become of the nations and it is evident that they are often vexed with forebodings. Will the nations finally destroy each other, or will espionage, intrigue, war and bloodshed go on interminably?

The Bible-believing Christian is not left in the dark about this, and certainly he entertains no false illusions about establishing peace on earth without the Prince of Peace. He sees the world headed straight toward its predicted judgment, when God will laugh at man's vain attempts to establish peace without His anointed Son on the throne. He remembers that great prophetic passage where the Father responds to man's rejection of His Son by saying to the Son: *"Sit Thou at My right hand until I make Thine enemies Thy footstool"* (Psa. 110:1). He remembers Psa. 2:1-5:

"Why do the nations rage, and the people[7] Imagine a vain thing?

"The kings of the earth set themselves, and the rulers take counsel together, against the Lord, and against His annointed, saying,

"Let us break their bands asunder, and cast away their cords from us.

"He that sitteth in the heavens shall laugh: the Lord shall have them in derision.

"Then shall He speak unto them in His wrath, and vex them in His sore displeasure."

Those who complain: "Why doesn't God *do* something?" should give thanks that for nineteen centuries since Christ was exiled from this earth God has remained silent, for when He speaks again it will be to "speak unto them in His wrath" and when He "does something," it will be to "vex them in His sore displeasure."

The believer recalls the prophecies of Daniel and of our Lord concerning this Christ-rejecting world:

". . . **there shall be a time of trouble such as never was since there was a nation even to that same time . . . " (Dan. 12:1).**

"For then shall be great tribulation, such as was not since the beginning of the world to this time, no nor ever shall be" (Matt. 24:21).

Unbelievers may consider us pessimists for believing these predictions, but in the light of fulfilled prophecy and of all the present indications we maintain that our faith rests upon a firmer foundation than does their unbelief. Furthermore, while it is nice to look on the bright side of things, mere optimism does not alter facts.

But the Bible-believer is not a pessimist, for he sees beyond the "great tribulation" to the coming of Christ to earth to reign as the royal Son of David. He recalls a great volume of Scripture prophecy on this subject, including such passages as the following:

"Behold, the days come, saith the Lord, that I will raise unto David a righteous Branch, and a King shall reign and prosper, and shall execute judgment and justice in the earth" (Jer. 23:5).

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[7] Of Israel. See Acts 4:25-27.

"And He shall judge among the nations, and shall rebuke many people: and they shall beat their swords into plowshares, and their spears into pruning hooks: nation shall not lift up sword against nation, neither shall they learn war any more" (Isa. 2:4).

The Bible-believer recalls scores of beautiful prophetic passages which describe the kingdom reign of Christ: how God Himself will reign in the person of Christ (Isa. 9:6,7), how government will be purified (Isa. 11:4), war and bloodshed will be abolished (Isa. 2:4), health and long life will be restored to the human race (Isa. 35:5,6; 65:20), the animal creation will be tamed (Isa. 11:6-9) and the curse will be removed from the vegetable creation (Isa. 35:1,2,6,7).

Yes, believers even believers of this present dispensation of grace, with their *heavenly* calling and position - look forward with eager anticipation to the fulfillment of Rev. 11:15:

"... **the kingdoms of this world are become the kingdoms of our Lord, and of His Christ: and He shall reign for ever and ever."**[8]

WHAT ABOUT THE JEW

Surely this is a relevant question, for the nations have had problems with the children of Israel for many centuries and "the Jewish question" simply will not be disposed of.

Other races and nations have been consumed or assimilated, but not the Jew. Empires have risen, fallen again and vanished, but the Jew, even since his dispersion over the whole world nineteen centuries ago, still retains his distinctive identity. Thus, while he is called "the international Jew," he is also called "the indestructible Jew" and "the imponderable Jew."

To the unbelieving world the Jew is an enigma. In the last few decades he has begun to return to the land which he left nineteen centuries ago. Though this land is now largely settled by Arab nations, the Jew claims that it belongs to him - all of it, and he wants to make it his home. Why is he not, like the Italians, the Germans and the French, assimilated by the nations in which he dwells? Why, after nineteen hundred years is he so distinctively Jewish, no matter where he lives or in what culture he is born and raised? The world does not know; it only finds itself constantly confronted with the problem.

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[8] Lit., "*unto the ages of the ages*," though the character of His reign will be altered *"when He shall have delivered up the kingdom to God, even the Father"* (I Cor. 15:24). See the author's book: *Things That Differ*.

But the Bible-believing Christian knows. He knows that it was prophesied thirty-four hundred years ago that Israel would "not be reckoned among the nations" (Num. 23:9). He knows that *God is* preserving the Jewish race for His own gracious purpose. He knows that the nations as such will never know salvation and blessing until they come to rejoice *with redeemed Israel,* dwelling safely in the land of Canaan (See Isa. 60:1-3; Jer. 23:5-8; Zech. 8:13,23; Rom. 15:8-12).

He knows that Israel, like the other nations, will go through the coming "tribulation," but that the prophesies which predict this also predict that this will be the time of her redemption. Thus we read in Jer. 30:7:

"Alas! for that day is great, so that none is like it: it is even the time of Jacob's trouble, but he shall be saved out of it."

How will Israel be saved out of it? Zech. 14:1-4 explains:

"Behold, the day of the Lord cometh, and thy spoil shall be divided in the midst of thee.

"For I will gather all nations against Jerusalem to battle; and the city shall be taken, and the houses rifled, and the women ravished; and half of the city shall go forth into captivity, and the residue of the people shall not be cut off from the city.

"Then shall the Lord go forth, and fight against those nations, as when He fought in the day of battle.

"And His feet shall stand in that day upon the Mount of Olives...."

The effect of Messiah's return to deliver His rebellious people will be dramatic:

" . . . **they shall look upon Me, whom they have pierced, and they shall mourn for Him as one mourneth for his only son, and shall be in bitterness for Him as one that is in bitterness for his firstborn" (Zech. 12:10).**

This repentance upon Israel's part will be met by ample mercy and grace on God's, as the next chapter goes on to show:

"In that day there shall be a fountain opened to the house of David and to the inhabitants of Jerusalem for sin and for uncleanness."

Thus the Apostle Paul declares in Rom. 11:26,27:

"And so all Israel shall be saved: as it Is written, There Shall come out of Sion the Deliverer, and shall turn away ungodliness from Jacob:

"For this Is my covenant unto them, when I shall take away their sins."

WHAT ABOUT THE CHURCH?

The Church, like the Jew, is an enigma to the world's wisest sages. The supposed representative of God, and enjoying the respect, even the reverence of millions, she is confused and divided, makes enormous blunders and, through the centuries has been guilty of incredible corruption. The writer's brother and his wife, missionaries in China, were beheaded by Communists, but Communism is but the natural reaction to a corrupt Church.

In general the world is disappointed in the Church because she looks to it to save the wreck which man has made, and feels that the Church should be the one to establish righteousness and peace in the earth.

This is a grave problem, but it has been created only because the world, including the religious world, does not even know what God is doing today. She is ignorant of His program, so clearly outlined in the Scriptures.

Intelligent, Bible-believing Christians know that it is not God's purpose to save the wreck, but rather to save lost souls *from* the wreck and add them to "the Body of Christ," the true Church of this present dispensation of grace.

The Bible-believer does not confuse the professing Church with the true Church of God. The former is an organization, or numerous organizations, with headquarters on earth. The latter is a living organism,[9] with Christ, its living Head, and its position and prospect in heaven.

Some, perhaps most, members of the living organism do indeed belong to the man-made organization and some are more, some less intelligent as to what the Bible teaches about the true Church, but believers in Christ, whether in or out of the various denominations, have been eternally and inseparably united with Christ as members of His Body (Rom. 12:5; I Cor. 12:12,27).

The man-made organization may demand submission to water baptism and/or other ordinances for membership, but instructed believers know that this is not founded upon the Word rightly divided. They know that whereas water baptism and other ordinances were required in the program of Christ *on earth*

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[9] It should be noted, however, that any *local* company of believers into an assembly may Scripturally be called a church (I Cor. 1:2, etc.). The local church is the earthly counterpart of the true Church, the Body of Christ.

and His twelve apostles, these have no relation to the glorified Lord and His program for today, committed by revelation to that other apostle, Paul.

"FOR BY ONE SPIRIT ARE WE ALL BAPTIZED INTO ONE BODY..." (I Cor. 12:13).

But what about the future of the Church? Great world leaders have made all sorts of predictions about this. Will it finally Crumble and fall, or will it emerge as the world's peacemaker and bring in everlasting righteousness? The great world leaders do not know. Some despise the Church, others look to it for guidance, but always with misgivings.

The intelligent Bible-believing Christians, however, immediately asks, *"Which Church?"*

What is the future of the *true* Church, the Body of Christ? He knows a secret about this, for Paul, the apostle of this dispensation, declares by divine inspiration:

"Behold, I show you a mystery [Lit., "tell you a secret"]; we shall not all sleep [in death] but we shall all be changed" (I Cor. 15:51).

In his letter to the Philippians the apostle explains *how* "we shall all be changed":

"For our citizenship is in heaven; from whence also we look for the Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ;

"Who shall change our vile [humiliated] body, that it may be fashioned like unto His glorious body, according to the working whereby He is able even to subdue all things unto Himself" (Phil. 3:20,21).

I Thes. 4:13-18 declares that at this time "the Lord Himself shall descend from heaven" and we believers will be "caught up. . . to meet the Lord in the air, and so shall we ever be with the Lord." A comparison of this passage with the following chapter indicates that this will take place *before* God's wrath is visited upon this earth.

With the true Church thus caught up to heaven, the apostate Church, the vast religious organization alone will be left. This is not the company of those upon whom Christ set His love, and who loved Him in return (Eph. 5:25-27). This is the multitude of those who are "religious" but do not even *know* Christ. While professing His name they have been anything but true to Him. Therefore this Church, left behind at our Lord's coming for His own, is called "The Harlot" (Rev. 17, 18). She is also called "Babylon," a fit name, since the apostate

organization has always been characterized by the confusion of tongues and by ceremonial idolatry - of which ancient Babylon was the fountainhead. Now all the apostate denominations will have united under this one head.

What will become of *this* Church? Read Revelation, Chapters 17 and 18, which clearly have to do with the apostate religious organization of the coming "tribulation." These chapters abound with such passages as the following:

"Come hither and I will show thee the judgment of the great harlot. . ." (17:1).

"Babylon the great is fallen, is fallen, and is become the habitation of devils, and the hold of every foul spirit, and a cage of every unclean and hateful bird" (18:2).

"Alas, alas, that great city Babylon, that mighty city! for in one hour is thy judgment come! (18:10).

How all this harmonizes with what we read in II Thes. 2:7-12:

"For the mystery of iniquity doth already work; only he who now letteth [hindereth] will let, until he be taken out of the way.

"And then shall that Wicked [one] be revealed, whom the Lord shall consume with the spirit of His mouth, and shall destroy with the brightness of His coming:

"Even him, whose coming is after the working of Satan with all power and signs and lying wonders,

"And with all deceivableness of unrighteousness in them that perish; because they received not the love of the truth, that they might be saved.

"And for this cause God shall send them strong delusion, that they should believe a lie:

"That they all might be damned who believed not the truth, but had pleasure in unrighteousness."

This brings us to our final question:

WHAT ABOUT ME?

Is it not amazing that men who can produce intricate electronic mechanisms, build giant skyscrapers, fly men to the moon and back-is it not amazing that such

men often do not even know what will finally become of themselves! And what is more amazing still is that most of them do not even try seriously to find out.

They are intelligent enough to plan carefully for the future where temporal affairs are concerned, but foolish enough to neglect their eternal welfare. They make plans for themselves *in case* they become ill and need additional funds for surgery, medicine and hospital care. They even make plans for their loved ones in case of death and bereavement, but they fail to ask themselves: "What will become of *me* after death?"

Daily "the wise of this world" witness the truth of Heb. 9:27, that *"it is appointed unto men once to die*," and most of them know that the Bible adds: *"after this the judgment*." They may hope that this is but a false alarm, but they do not know. They can only wonder and worry. Heb. 2:15 declares that *"through fear of death"* they are "*all their life subject to bondage."* Like Adam, they run and hide from God instead of running to Him and asking: *"What must I do to be saved?"* Too cowardly to face up to their own lost condition, they wander on with no light beyond the grave, no hope beyond the tomb - too afraid, generally, to even discuss death.

The believer in the Word of God is not left thus in the dark. He glories in the truth of the passages from which we have quoted in part above. We quote them now in full:

Heb. 2:14,15: "Forasmuch then as the children [of Adam] are partakers of flesh and blood, He [Christ] also Himself likewise took part of the same; that through death He might destroy him that had the power of death, that is, the devil;

"And deliver them who through fear of death were all their lifetime subject to bondage."

Heb. 9:27,28: "And as it is appointed unto men once to die, but after this the judgment.

"So Christ was once offered to bear the sins of many, and unto them that look for Him shall He appear the second time without [Lit., apart from] sin unto salvation."

What a difference this makes in one's outlook! Believing that Christ had died for *his* sins, and toiling tirelessly day after day to let others know, the Apostle Paul could say: *"For to me to live is Christ, and to die is gain."*

Chapter IV

THE DAY OF ITCHING EARS

For the professing Church the day of theological controversy has passed. *Ecumenism* is now the word on every tongue. Church leaders appear to have become convinced that the stifling confusion in the Church can be overcome only by all of us getting together, minimizing our differences and emphasizing those doctrines on which we all agree. As a result some of the most important doctrines of Scripture are neither denied nor affirmed; they are ignored. But little matter, for the objective now is not to be true to the written Word of God, but to see to it that the Church is "strong" and commands the world's respect.

Ecumenism, sad to say, has made significant inroads among evangelical believers too. All too seldom do men of God stand up to defend by the Scriptures the truths they believe and proclaim. The theological debate has given place to the dialogue, in which two individuals or groups sit down together to discuss their differences and see if there is not some basis for agreement.[10] This appears generous and objective but too often convictions are compromised and the truth watered down by such undertakings, with the result that the Spirit's power is sacrificed for numerical strength. No man of God can speak in the power of the Spirit when he places *anything* before the Word and Will of God. Nor can the Church ever be truly united and strong unless *she* puts God's Word and Will first and takes her place in the world as Christ's embassy on alien territory (See II Cor. 5:20).

But what do the Scriptures say about this new "open-mindedness," this new "let's all get together" trend?

OUR LORD'S WARNING

During our Lord's earthly ministry He warned His disciples: *"Take heed and beware of the leaven of the Pharisees and of the Sadducees"* (Matt. 16:6).

The disciples did not immediately grasp the significance of the Lord's warning. Realizing that they had forgotten to take bread with them they supposed that He referred to the leaven which their bakers used, and concluded that the Pharisees and Sadducees were evidently out to poison their food!

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[10] It is a strange and interesting fact, however, that few Church leaders or organizations seem interested to sit down in dialogue with one particular group: that which proclaims the *Scriptural* basis for unity, the truth of the "*one Body*" and its "*one baptism*" (Eph. 4:1-6).

To correct this mistake our Lord had but to remind them how, with but a few loaves, He had fed five thousand people at one time and four thousand at another. They themselves had taken up basketsful of the fragments on both occasions. Surely, then, *He* could supply them with food!

"Then understood they how that He bade them not beware of the leaven of bread, but of the doctrine of the Pharisees and of the Sadducees" (Ver. 12).

Someone *was* out to poison them - spiritually! It is doubtful that the Pharisees and Sadducees meant to propagate poisonous doctrines, but in their pride and hypocrisy they were the ready tools of Satan. It was because of the destructive qualities of these doctrines that our Lord had used the term "leaven" to describe them. Where false doctrine is concerned, it takes but a little to do a great deal of harm. Referring to this very thing Paul warned the Galatians that "a *little leaven leaveneth the whole lump*" (Gal. 5:9).

What was so dangerous about the teachings of the Pharisees and of the Sadducees? In general it was that the Pharisees *added* to the written Word (Matt. 23) and the Sadducees took from it (Acts 23:8). *Both were dangerous,* and our Lord warned His disciples to *BEWARE of* both. We do well to take this lesson to heart, for the Pharisees and Sadducees are with us still - those who add to the Word of God and those who take from it.

THE DOCTRINE OF THE PHARISEES

"The doctrine of the Pharisees" has held a prominent place in the Church throughout its history. The Reformation did not put an end to it by any means, for still today vast numbers of religious people subscribe to it.

Church leaders have added all sorts of rituals, restrictions and requirements to God's revealed program for His Church in this dispensation of grace, and multitudes of sincere believers follow like sheep instead of searching the Scriptures daily to see whether these things really do belong to His program for our day.

Look at the members of Christ's Body. Many are under the Law, while others are trying to recover the miraculous signs of Pentecost, or are striving to carry out a "great commission" that is not theirs. They observe holy days, baptism, foot-washing and all sorts of other forms and ceremonies which are contrary to God's program for this dispensation, as revealed in the epistles of Paul. As a result the Church is a Babel of confusion and Satan is well satisfied.

How perverse is the heart of man! God reveals the Substance and lo, His people go back to the shadows! He demonstrates the all-sufficiency of Christ’s

redemptive work and behold, His people continue to observe the rites that pointed to it. Indeed, they add ceremonies which He never commanded at all! In grace God postpones the judgment and the earthly reign of Christ, to offer grace and reconciliation to His enemies and lo, His servants do not even understand and go about vainly trying to "establish His kingdom."

They do not *deny* that we are commissioned to proclaim God's offer of grace and reconciliation, but they *add another commission* and so confuse the God-given message. They do not *deny* the all-sufflciency of Christ's finished work, but they *add* unscriptural and undispensational teachings and forms and ceremonies, and so confuse and adulterate God's clear message of grace.

This is "the doctrine of the Pharisees" and it is *dangerous*.

Added error blinds men's minds to the truth. Those who add the so-called "Great Commission" to God's program for this dispensation cannot fully appreciate the glory of our Lord's "great commission" to Paul and to us (II Cor. 5:14-21; Eph. 3:8,9; *et al*). Those who go back under the Law of Moses or even back to Pentecost cannot fully appreciate the glory of our Lord's finished work or "the exceeding riches of His grace." Those who observe foot-washing, water baptism or holy days cannot fully understand the mystery of God's purpose and grace. These added things hang as a veil before their eyes and blind them to the glories of their position in the heavenlies in Christ as members of His Body.

Our Lord charged the Pharisees with "teaching for doctrines the commandments of men" and with "making the Word of God of none effect through [their] traditions" (Mark 7:7,13). This is being done on every hand today as religious leaders add to God's glorious "grace" program ceremonies and observances which belonged to former dispensations or which He never commanded at all. This is dangerous to our spiritual welfare and we should "beware" of it.

THE DOCTRINE OF THE SADDUCEES

But if Satan cannot deceive us with "the doctrine of the Pharisees" he will seek to accomplish his purpose through "the doctrine of the Sadducees."

In comparison with the bigoted Pharisees, the Sadducees were the "advanced thinkers" of their day. Not that they did not also substitute human tradition for the Word of God, but they made more of the human intellect and refused to believe certain truths which were supernatural in character. The Sadducees have a host of followers in our day with its emphasis on the intellectual.

But our Lord *warned* His disciples against the Sadducees too. He said *"Take heed.... Beware*" and described their doctrine as leaven because a little of it can spread so fast.

This warning is sorely needed today, since some sincere Christians, wishing to be intellectual and open-minded, place themselves in positions of grave spiritual danger.

On the premise that they are mature and are seeking for the truth, such people often spend their time examining all the different viewpoints they can find and so make shipwreck of the faith. We should be careful about assuming that we are mature either intellectually or spiritually. To the puffed-up Corinthian believers Paul wrote:

"Let no man deceive himself. If any man among you seemeth to be wise In this world, let him become [take the position of] a fool, that he may be wise" (I Cor. 3:18).

"And if any man think that he knoweth anything, he knoweth nothing yet as he ought to know" (I Cor. 8:2).

The fact is that we cannot trust our intellects. Surely the sharp disagreements among the world's greatest intellects should teach us this. These disagreements exist because, as the Bible teaches, the human mind, like the human heart, has become depraved by sin.

THE THESSALONIANS, THE BEREANS AND THE ATHENIANS

But were not the Bereans commended for listening with open minds to teachings which they had never heard before? Yes, when they were *confronted* with them. It was the Athenians, *not* the Bereans, who made it their policy to consider as many viewpoints as possible on every subject (Acts 17:18-21).

The strength of the Bereans was that *they kept close to the Scriptures.* When *confronted* with some new doctrine, they did indeed give it an interested hearing, but then *"searched the Scriptures daily whether those things were so"* (Acts 17:11). Had they found anything in Paul's message which contradicted the Scriptures they would immediately have rejected it. And for this God calls them "noble." They were the truly great, the spiritual aristocracy of their day.

Too many believers today aspire to be like the Athenians rather than the Bereans. They say they wish to have open minds, and this is good if it is remembered that an open mind is like an open mouth; not everything should be put into it.

The Athenians went to the other extreme from the Thessalonians, who would not even consider a new doctrine when *confronted* with it - would not even consider it in the light of the Scriptures.

The Bereans were the wisest of the three. They kept close to that blessed Book, and, when confronted with unfamiliar teachings, immediately subjected them to the test of Scripture.

This is the wisest course even if only because we are all limited in time and strength. Obviously we cannot spend a great deal of time looking into the conflicting teachings of men without sacrificing a great deal of much-needed time for Bible study, and in the measure that we do this we are bound to grow spiritually weaker.

THE QUESTION OF EXPOSURE

There are those who argue that believers cannot be strengthened against error without being exposed to it. Our Lord knew better. He did not invite the Pharisees and the Sadducees to address His audiences. Rather He *warned* His audiences against the "leaven" of the Pharisees and the Sadducees and kept teaching His hearers *the truth*. The depravity of the human heart and mind is such that the believer is not strengthened against error by constant exposure to it; he is strengthened against error by feeding consistently upon the Word of God. Exposure to error strengthens the believer only as it drives him to the Word of God. Show me a Christian who is always "considering all sides" and I will show you one who will fail dismally to give the Scriptural answer to false teaching-if indeed he is not taken in by false teaching himself. But show me a Christian who spends his time with that blessed Book and I will show you one who, strong in the faith, can easily answer his adversaries by the Scriptures. Paul wrote to young Pastor Timothy:

"I charge thee therefore before God, and the Lord Jesus Christ.... Preach the Word.... For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine; but after their own lusts shall they heap to themselves teachers, having itching ears" (II Tim. 4:1-3).

And what was to be the result of this "itching ears" condition, this passion to hear teachers of all schools of thought expound their various doctrines? Hear the divine prediction:

"And they shall turn away their ears from the truth, and shall be turned unto fables" (Ver. 4).

What thoughtful student of the Word will deny that we have reached this point in the history of the professing Church, that the day of "itching cars" is upon us?

The desire to "give everyone a hearing," as it were, may seem superficially to indicate spiritual greatness but actually it is of the flesh and is based upon the exalted presumption that it is safe for me to trust my intellect, even though the greatest intellects have disagreed over the most vital subjects. Where our intellects are concerned we are wiser to heed the Spirit-inspired exhortation of one truly great intellect, the Apostle Paul:

"Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth Itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing Into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ" (II Cor. 10:5).

The Apostle Paul did not assume that his followers were mature enough to consider all religious viewpoints. He delivered his God-given message and *warned* his hearers and readers against false teachings.

To the Corinthians he wrote:

"But I fear, lest by any means, as the serpent beguiled Eve through his subtlety, so your minds should be corrupted from the simplicity that is in Christ" (II Cor. 11:3).

Reminding the Colossians of his labor and strife and toil and conflict to establish them in the faith, he warns:

"Beware lest any man spoil [rob] you. . . . Let no man beguile you . . ." (Col. 2:8,18).

He did not suggest to the Ephesian elders that it might be big of them occasionally to invite the legalists or the gnostics or some other heterodox teachers in to address their audiences. He rather impressed upon them their responsibility to protect their congregations from false teaching. Read carefully and prayerfully his very words, as found in Acts 20:28-31:

"Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over the which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers, to feed the Church of God, which He hath purchased with His own blood.

"For I know this, that after my departing shall grievous wolves enter in among you, not sparing the flock.

"Also of your own selves shall men arise, speaking perverse things, to draw away disciples after them.

"Therefore watch, and remember, that by the space of three years I ceased not to warn every one night and day with tears."

Even those two outstanding pastors, Timothy and Titus, were warned against the "leaven" of false teaching. The apostle exhorts Timothy:

"Take heed unto thyself and unto the doctrine; continue In them: for in doing this thou shalt both save thyself and them that hear thee" (I Tim. 4:16).

This passage explains why some pastors have been unable to save their hearers from error and spiritual shipwreck. Certainly it teaches the *danger* of false doctrine to both pastor and people.

Throughout his two epistles to Timothy the apostle *warns* his son in the faith against those who *"teach otherwise"* and exhorts him to *"fight the good fight of the faith."* How earnestly he beseeches young Timothy to stay close to the Word of God and especially to the Word of God committed to *him* for *this present* dispensation:

"O TIMOTHY, KEEP [GUARD] THAT WHICH IS COMMITTED TO THY TRUST, AVOIDING ... OPPOSITIONS OF SCIENCE FALSELY SO CALLED" (I Tim. 6:20).

"HOLD FAST THE FORM OF SOUND WORDS, WHICH THOU HAST HEARD OF ME....

"THAT GOOD THING WHICH WAS COMMITTED UNTO THEE KEEP [GUARD] BY THE HOLY GHOST WHICH DWELLETH IN US" (II Tim. 1:13,14).

In his letter to Titus the apostle declares that a bishop must be "blameless as the steward of God" (Tit. 1:7) :

"HOLDING FAST THE FAITHFUL WORD . . . THAT HE MAY BE ABLE BY SOUND DOCTRINE BOTH TO EXHORT AND TO CONVINCE THE GAINSAYERS" (Ver. 9).

Never does Paul advise even the strongest, most mature man of God to seek out the doctrines of those who "teach otherwise" so that they may know how to deal with them. He rather exhorts them to keep strong in the truth, ever ready to meet false doctrine with *the Word of God.*

False doctrine is nothing to toy with. Our Lord described it as "leaven," a little of which can quickly permeate "the whole loaf." How many a sincere Christian has had his faith wrecked in a liberal theological seminary! He went in with his eyes open, sure that *his* faith would never be shaken, but contending that this seminary had a high scholastic standing and there would be much to learn there. As a result he was drawn more and more from the study of the Word to the study of the varied and conflicting opinions of men. Soon his early convictions were neutralized and he could no longer preach the Word in the power of the Spirit.

There are those who teach that Christian young people should even expose themselves to the immoral writings of those who glory in their shame-so that they will be better prepared to face the realities of life. But Paul wrote by divine inspiration: *"I would have you wise unto that which is good, and simple concerning evil"* (Rom. 16:19). Our young people will be prepared to meet the realities of life as they are confronted with them, only in the measure that they are strong in the faith. It is "the whole armor of God," and this alone, that can protect us against the "wiles" and the "fiery darts" of the devil and help us to "withstand in the evil day" (Eph. 6:10-18).

A truly great man of God once told this writer that he was sorry he had ever read Tom Paine's *Age of Reason.* He had faced up to Paine's teachings and had come through with complete faith in the Bible, intellectually as well as in heart. Yet there were deductions and conclusions from Paine's book which kept coming back to his mind to plague him. How much he would have given to forget them now!

When you are confronted with the familiar sign, "BEWARE OF THE DOG," be wise and keep out of the way. If you ignore the warning and have to flee, torn and bruised, *that is your fault*. Nor can you expect God to protect you from spiritual harm and loss if you ignore His admonition to beware of false doctrine.

Do not presume: "I am mature. I will never be confused or overthrown by error." *BEWARE!* This is the course of *obedience*. This is the course of *wisdom*. This is the course of *humility*.

Every believer should remember that *"the natural man receiveth not the things of the Spirit of God ... because they are spiritually discerned"* (I Cor. 2:14). It was by the Spirit that our eyes were opened to the most vital truths which confront mankind. Therefore it behooves us to protect ourselves from error and spiritual harm by consistent, prayerful, believing study of that blessed Book of which the Spirit is the Author.

Is this anti-intellectualism? Is it anti-intellectual of the child to say to his father: "Dad, you know much more about this subject than I do; I will listen to what you have to say"? No, this is the child's greatest wisdom.

Let us never forget that "*the fear of the Lord is the beginning of wisdom"* (Prov. 9:10). On this all *true* wisdom is based and surely true wisdom is more to be desired than mere intellectual acumen. The Word of God has much to say about the honors which He will confer upon the truly wise, and it also has much to say about the folly of those who glorify the human intellect.

Concerning those who find it intellectually impossible to accept the Bible as the Word of God or to bow to it in faith; concerning them this great Book, which has, not barely, but handsomely withstood all the arguments of its critics, says: *"The wisdom of this world is foolishness with God"* (I Cor. 3:19) and surely this has been conclusively demonstrated! Such would do well to consider the challenge of I Cor. 1:18-25 and face up to it.

Chapter V

WHAT IS TRUTH?

"Pilate saith unto Him, What is truth? And when he had said this, he went out.

- John 18:38

For this some have called Judaea's governor "jesting Pilate," but the sacred Record indicates that he was by no means in a jesting mood that fateful day. Rather, we believe, this was the voice of cynicism. During "the four hundred silent years" between Malachi and Matthew God had held His peace, as it were, and had allowed the world's great philosophers, Plato, Socrates, Aristotle and others, to do the talking. But the philosophies of these noted thinkers had left Pilate still lost and confused. For him there was no authoritative Voice, no Source to which one could turn in confidence to learn the truth.

Thus when our Lord spoke about the truth the governor said-note, he didn't ask; he *said*, cynically, "What is truth?" and went out without even waiting for an answer. This is the attitude of increasing numbers of "intelligent" people in our day.

WHAT IS TRUTH?

The knowledge of the truth should be the final goal of man's intellectual and spiritual endeavors. With so much at stake one is foolhardy to allow himself to become cynical where the truth is concerned. Rather keep searching, searching unremittingly as long as life shall last than to set this important matter aside. Rather toil and sacrifice until death, in fruitless quest of the truth than to become cynical and live on - for what?

We *must* come to know the truth or be left to drift hopelessly on an open sea of human speculation, never certain, never confident, never at rest.

But "what is truth"?

First, there is a difference between *truths* and *the truth*. One may know many truths yet fail to know the *truth. The truth*, in general usage, and especially in the Bible, is that which may be fully and finally relied upon and trusted as authentic, even authoritative. *The truth* is the source of all truth.

There are four general subjects taught at our colleges and universities which are looked upon, perhaps, as the most probable sources of truth. These are:

history, science, philosophy and religion. But can *the truth* be found in the pursuit of any of these studies? Let us see.

HISTORY

Much of the data in our history books is doubtless correct and there are many important lessons we may learn from history, since the same causes generally produce the same effects. But is history completely reliable? Can we place our *trust*, our *implicit confidence*, in history as *the truth*? Clearly we cannot, for the historian's background, his politics, his religion all have a bearing on his viewpoint and tend to affect his writings.

To see how *un*reliable history can be one need but compare an English history of the Revolutionary War with an American history of the same war, or compare northern and southern histories of our own Civil War! The differences and contradictions will be pronounced.

THE SCIENCES

Likewise there is much scientific data that is unquestionably true. But is science completely reliable? Can we fully trust it as *the truth*? Clearly not, for after all science is only what man has learned - or thinks he has learned - about nature.

Granting the amazing strides that science has made in the last century, still in the long view it has proved far from completely reliable. Five hundred years ago every one knew that the earth was flat. There was no question about it. It was a demonstrable fact! It was also a demonstrable fact that the sun travelled around the earth. One could *see* it rise in the cast in the morning, travel across the heaven and set in the west in the evening. This "fact" of science was supported by a daily demonstration apparently as convincing as some of those we now advance to prove that the earth is round and that *it* travels around the sun! Thus what appeared to be scientifically true five hundred years ago has since been proven false.

As to the science of medicine, which plays so great a part in our health and physical well-being, yesterday's "facts" are being daily disproved and replaced by new scientific data which may or may not be correct.

Psychology is perhaps that branch of science to which most people turn for the truth - at least the truth about themselves - and psychiatrists are doing a land-office business treating mental illnesses. The trouble is that the vast majority of psychologists, psychoanalysts and psychiatrists overlook one basic factor in man's make-up: the fall. They do not see *sin* as the root cause of man's wretchedness, and, working on the wrong premise, they are bound to come to

wrong conclusions. Generally sin is labeled sickness. A man commits a moral outrage and they say he is sick; they even tell *him* that.

We went to call on a Christian man some time ago who had fallen into horrible immorality and it had caught up with him. For years his sanctimonious life had been a sham, but now the mask was torn off and he was in trouble - deep trouble.

We had been telling him that now his best course was to honestly confess his guilt to the courts *and to God,* but he didn't seem to feel his guilt. Someone had gotten to him first - a clergyman, who had said to his wife in his presence: "We must help him to see that he is ill and needs help. Not that I condone what he's done, but I think that if we give him the proper psychiatric help he can overcome this weakness."

Of course the man was sick! We would all be sick if we sank to the moral depths to which he had sunk. But let us get this straight: his sin was not the result of his sickness; his sickness was the result of his sin.

Looking at it even from the psychiatrist's viewpoint, this man would have been much more apt to find relief from his guilt and overcome his sin if he had been exhorted to recognize it for what it was and had sobbed his heart out in penitence to God as did David of old (See Psalms 32 and 51).

If the truth, then, is not to be found in the above sciences shall we find it in sociology, biology, mathematics, physics or the remaining sciences? No, for science is only knowledge gained from study and experiment; it is nothing in itself and our "findings" are as apt to be erroneous as we are to err.

PHILOSOPHY

Many people believe that the truth is to be found in philosophy, for what is philosophy but a search for truth?

Many of the postulates and propositions of philosophy are indeed valid, but is philosophy completely reliable? Can we place implicit confidence in the philosophical tenets of the world's great thinkers? Obviously not, else why the sharp disagreements between the various philosophical schools of thought and the constant shift from one popular philosophy to another?

Philosophy is indeed man's *quest* for truth, and it is *therefore* not itself the truth.

Moreover most philosophers, like most psychologists, ignore or deny the fact of sin. They witness and experience trouble, sorrow, misery and death and the

evident fact that within us, as all about us, there is a positive *dis*location of things, which normally causes them to go wrong rather than right. But they do not - will not - recognize this factor as due to the fall of man. If they recognized the nature and condition of man they would cry to God for mercy and trust Christ as their Savior, but their philosophical systems are generally given to self-justification even self-glorification, and they go on in their quest, "ever learning, and never able to come to the knowledge of *the truth*" (II Tim. 3:7).

RELIGION

This brings us to *religion*, where probably the majority of people believe the truth is, if anywhere, to be found. But what is religion? The word comes from the Latin, *taboo*, *restraint*. In popular usage it refers to the service and worship of God as expressed in denominational *systems*, with their forms and ceremonies.

Here the confusion and division is even greater than that prevailing in science and philosophy. This need not have been so had our spiritual leaders kept faithfully to the Source of all truth and spoken "as the oracles of God" (I Pet. 4:11). But refusing the truth, popular religious leaders have reduced their profession to that of philosophy, in which *they* in their "wisdom" decide what must be the truth as to the justice and love of God, the inspiration of His Word, the deity of Christ, salvation, heaven, hell, etc.

Even Bible-believing fundamentalists are confused and divided because, when God had blessed His people with increased light on His Word and we stood at the very threshold of blessing and unity never before experienced, and spiritual power to match it, our leaders refused to enter in and warned their followers against entering in. When our Lord proclaimed "the gospel of the kingdom" the spiritual leaders opposed Him and He rebuked them with the words:

"Woe unto you ... for ye have taken away the key of knowledge. Ye entered not in yourselves, and them that were entering in ye hindered" (Luke 11:52).

Those who have proclaimed the unadulterated "gospel of the grace of God" have experienced the same sort of opposition from twentieth century spiritual leaders. This is because these leaders stood, not only at the threshold of glorious opportunity; they also stood at moral crossroads as God in His grace recovered for us the glorious truth of the "ONE body" with its "ONE baptism."

What precious unity, what spiritual power, these truths from Paul's epistles offer to the Church! What divisions, self-interest and rancor they erase! But the cure, to the leaders, seemed worse than the disease, for their careers, their

positions, their salaries, were founded on denominational *division* and the varied baptisms by which applicants were admitted to their respective communions.

Now there are strong movements to overcome this division by artificial means. "Just let's unite on those things in which we *do* agree, and get busy winning souls for Christ." This is the argument by which doctrinal beliefs are reduced to a bare minimum and increasing numbers are prepared for the United Church of Antichrist which will be left to go through the "great tribulation" after our Lord has brought the dispensation of grace to a close by calling His own to Himself (See I Thes. 4:16-5:9 and II Thes. 2:1-12).

Thus religion today, while often it does things in a big way, is still *the confusion of tongues.* All the enormous evangelistic efforts of the past two decades have left little impression on the masses. Indeed crime and godlessness continue to *increase faster than ever.* All the efforts of true believers at achieving unity have failed, because true unity is enjoyed only by *faith* in the *truth* proclaimed by Paul that we are one, baptized into Christ and His body by *the Spirit* (See Rom. 6:3; 12:5; I Cor. 12:12,13,27; Eph. 4:3-6). Thank God, those who see this blessed truth may enjoy the most precious unity - oneness in Christ-and may even feel their spiritual oneness with denominational brethren who do rot it!

But with history, science, philosophy and religion all in a state of confusion and discord, where shall we turn for *the truth*? Only one answer remains: *To God!*

THE TRUTH

God has graciously revealed Himself to man in a twofold manner: (1) Through, Christ, the living Word, and (2) through the Bible, the written Word. Both our Lord Jesus Christ and the Holy Scriptures are *called* "the Word" in the Bible, since they reveal God to us, and both are called "*the* truth." Christ and the Bible *are* the truth because they *are* the Word of *God.*

CHRIST THE LIVING WORD

No part of the Bible presents Christ as God so clearly as does John's “gospel."

"In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (John 1:1).

"No man hath seen God at any time,, the only begotten Son, which is in the bosom of the Father, He hath declared Him [shown Him forth]" (John 1:18).

"Jesus saith....

"if ye had known Me, ye should have known My Father also: and from henceforth ye know Him and have seen Him.

"Philip saith unto Him, Lord, show us the Father and it sufficeth us.

"Jesus saith unto him, Have I been so long time with you, and yet hast thou not known Me, Philip? He that hath seen Me hath seen the Father, and how sayest thou then, Show us the Father?" (John 14:6-9).

Our Lord revealed God, not only in His words, but in *Himself.* The mighty power of His teachings lay in the fact that He was the personification of all He taught. He, alone of all men, could say, without tongue in cheek:

"I am ... THE TRUTH . . ." (John 14:6).

He could say, without sounding foolish or hypocritical:

"Which of you convinceth Me of sin?" (John 8:46).

He could say with simplicity and dignity:

"If ye continue in My word ... ye shall know the truth and the truth shall make you free" (John 8:31,32).

This is why Eph. 4:21 refers to the truth *as it is in Jesus.* He was the personification of the truth of God; completely reliable. As one could trust His words one could trust *Him* and this is still so, only His words particularly addressed *to us* are those which He committed to Paul after His exaltation to heaven (Eph. 3:1-4).

Amazing love, that Christ, the Truth, should die in shame and disgrace as a wrong-doer, *44* made ... sin" for us sinners *"that we might be made the righteousness of* God in Him" (II Cor. 5:21).

THE BIBLE THE WRITTEN WORD

The Bible is unique among books as Christ was among men, in that it is the only book that claims repeatedly and consistently to be *the truth.*

It begins with the majestic words: "In *the beginning God. . .* ." It does not argue the case; it simply states it. The sacramental introduction to the

prophecies is: *"Thus saith the Lord,"* and a hundred fulfilled prophecies prove that the Bible is indeed the Word of God - *the truth*.

Without apology it refers to:

The "manifestation of the truth" (II Cor. 4:2).

The "knowledge of the truth" (II Tim. 3:7).

Those who "have erred concerning the truth" (II Tim. 2:18).

Those who "resist the truth" (II Tim. 3:8).

Those who "hold down [suppress] the truth in unrighteousness" (Rom. 1:18).

Those who "turn away their ears from the truth" (II Tim. 4:4).

Those who "believe and know the truth" (I Tim. 4:3).

Those who "acknowledge the truth" (Tit. 1:1).

Our Lord said to His Father: "Thy Word is truth" (John 17:17).

Paul wrote to those who were saved when they "heard the word of truth, the gospel of [their] salvation" (Eph. 1:13).

We are instructed to "rightly divide the Word of truth," that we may be "approved unto God ... workmen who need not to be ashamed" (II Tim. 2:15).

Where the truth is concerned God's Word is all we need, for:

"All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness;

"That the man of God may be perfect [complete], THOROUGHLY FURNISHED unto all good works" (II Tim. 3:16,17).

Those who have placed intelligent faith in the Bible, the written Word, and thus in Christ, the living Word, have found them to be indeed *the truth,* without one flaw or failure to cause distrust - and with a thousand noble virtues to inspire complete and enduring confidence.

Chapter VI

NO OTHER DOCTRINE

Thoughtful students of the Word are becoming increasingly convinced that we are living in the closing days of what Paul, by divine inspiration, called "this present evil age."

Everything about us appears to be in ferment. The races, the nations, labor, industry, politics, society, education and religion are all in a turmoil. The apostasy has risen like a flood tide, with fundamentalists leaning toward liberalism and liberals increasingly inclined toward godlessness. The rebellion of the age is reflected in a hundred ways, including a car sticker which is now popular in many places. It reads: "FORGET HELL."

In times like these the epistles of Paul to Timothy afford special help to the sincere child of God.

THE EPISTLES TO TIMOTHY

Of all Paul's friends Timothy was in many ways the closest. The apostle calls him "*my own son in the faith"* (I Tim. 1:2). He mentions him in the majority of his epistles, sometimes as a co-writer.

Not dreaming that the dispensation of grace would last for 1900 years, but expecting that the Lord would soon come for His own,[11] the apostle instructs Timothy as to how *he* should conduct himself in "the last days." But God *did know* that the dispensation of grace would be thus extended. He had planned it so. Indeed, He had *inspired* Paul to write to Timothy and has since incorporated these letters into the Holy Bible, so that Paul's words to Timothy have become God's Word to us, meant especially to help us to stand true to Him amid the apostasy of the closing days of the dispensation of grace.

APOSTASY THEN AND NOW

With this in mind, let us consider the apostle's opening exhortation to Timothy, his son in the faith.

"As I besought thee to abide still at Ephesus, when I went into Macedonia, that thou mightest charge some that they teach no other doctrine,

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[11] See I Cor. 15:51: Phil. 3:20; I Thes. 1:9,10; Tit. 2:13, et al.

"Neither give heed to fables and endless genealogies, which minister questions rather than godly edifying which is in faith: so do" (I Tim. 1:3,4).

The reader will recall that when Paul had visited with the Ephesian elders on the way to Jerusalem some years before, he had said:

"Take heed therefore unto yourselves, and to all the flock, over which the Holy Ghost hath made you overseers, to feed the church of God, which He hath purchased with His own blood.

"For I know this, that after my departing shall grievous wolves enter in among you, not sparing the flock.

"Also of your own selves shall men arise, speaking perverse things to draw away disciples after them.

"Therefore watch, and remember, that by the space of three years I ceased not to warn every one night and day with tears" (Acts 20:28-31).

Paul's predictions had come true. There were now people in the church at Ephesus who were teaching other doctrines and drawing away disciples after them, and the apostle found it necessary to write a letter to Timothy urging him to face up to the situation without wavering.

As we have pointed out, however, Paul's words to Timothy are now God's Word to us, given to arm us against the rising tide of apostasy.

TEACH NO OTHER DOCTRINE

In strong language the apostle bids Timothy *to "charge* some that they teach no other doctrine"; no other doctrine, obviously, than that which *he* had taught them. He uses the same phraseology in I Tim. 6:3-5, where he closes his epistle by saying:

"If any man teach otherwise, and consent not to wholesome words, even the words of our Lord Jesus Christ[12] ... from such withdraw thyself."

In these passages the apostle emphasizes the importance of fidelity to that heaven-sent message committed particularly to him; that message which he says in Tit. 1:2,3, was "promised before the ages began" but made known "in due times . . . *through preaching which is committed unto me. . . ."*

[12] Cf. II Cor. 13:3.

Ever since Paul's day religious leaders have substituted other messages for that committed by revelation to Paul. The law of Moses, the Sermon on the Mount, the "great commission," and Pentecost have all been confused with God's message and program for the dispensation of grace. This is what has bewildered and divided the Church and ripened it for the apostasy.

With all the confused thinking about the Ten Commandments and the Sermon on the Mount fifty years ago it was little wonder that modernism swept so many off their feet with its teachings about Jesus of Nazareth, the Man of Galilee, following His footsteps, social betterment, political reform, etc. Multitudes were so taken up with the social gospel, so eager to help make the world a better place to live in, that they did not even notice or believe that the modernists denied the very fundamentals of the Christian faith.

But the new evangelicalism of our day is still more dangerous. It is big. It is well financed. It is popular. It is subtle. Perhaps its greatest danger lies in the fact that while claiming to be "conservative," it minimizes the importance of the fundamentals and the danger of apostatizing from them. Neo-evangelicals often scoff at separation from the world and join with apostate unbelievers in efforts to win souls for Christ. They encourage more dialogue with liberals and urge a reconsideration of the fundamentals, especially the doctrine of the inerrancy of the Scriptures. Indeed they prefer the word adequacy to inerrancy, and feel it would be ground gained if we could get together with the liberals on the basis that the Scriptures are adequate. If they meant by this that the Scriptures are all we need for faith and conduct, we would agree, but this is definitely *not* the case. They have chosen the word *adequate* in preference to the word *inerrant*, as a compromise with liberal theologians, thus casting reflections on the perfection and infallibility of God's Word.

Because of this permissive attitude toward doctrine and conduct all sorts of unscriptural teachings are being openly proclaimed among "conservative" believers. Thus the inspired words of the Apostle Paul: *"Charge some that they teach no other doctrine*," are more needed today than they were in his own.

DON'T PAY ATTENTION TO STORIES

But the apostle continues: "*neither give heed to fables."*

As the present-day English reader comes upon the word "fables" in the *Authorized* Version, he is apt to think of *Aesop's Fables,* but these were illustrations,[13] while the original word *muthois* means simply stories, including stories of imagined incidents or events.

[13] Our Lord used many illustrations; so did Paul, though Paul's did not take the form of narratives.

There are two types of stories that have exerted an amazing influence upon twentieth century Christendom. One is the novel, the other the promotional story.

In considering the above passage, this writer examined the contents of the popular Christian periodicals coming to his desk and was astonished to find how many of them were largely filled with fiction and with stories written to promote projects or viewpoints. The apostle says about such stories that they raise questions but do not answer them, for stories really prove nothing. This is also true of many Christian films.

Many Christian novels have indeed exerted a savory influence upon their readers[14] - when they have been founded upon Scriptural truths and principles. Obviously, however, an author can make his novel "prove" exactly what he wishes to prove, for the novel involves us in a world of make-believe. Thus a novel *can* be dangerous to Christian faith and practice. In other writings we have discussed one novel which downgrades Scriptural separation and makes sincere fundamentalists look ridiculous and ineffective as soul-winners, while "those worldly Griscoms" win souls to Christ by skipping church on Sunday and joining their unsaved neighbors at the beach. You can do this in a novel or a movie and lead sincere but unwary Christian readers into courses of action which are diametrically opposed to the teachings of Scripture.

The promotional story holds, perhaps, an even more prominent place in our popular Christian magazines. No one can object to factual reports of what God has wrought, but too many of these stories are nothing more than promotional efforts. One has the feeling that they are not strictly true to fact; that whatever favors the writer's objective is related in glowing and exaggerated terms, while other pertinent information is omitted. In a word, many of these "success stories" are *so* successful that thoughtful readers question their validity and are apt to lay them aside without even finishing them. Less discerning readers, however, are often deeply moved by them.

Christian Life, for example, has done much to make Pentecostalism and the alleged gift of tongues popular even in many of our larger denominations. But this periodical could never have accomplished this by a direct consideration of God's Word on the subject. It did so by publishing story after story after story of alleged miraculous demonstrations of God's power in this area-and many people are convinced by accounts of human experience. A convert to tongues-speaking once said to this writer: "I don't care what the Bible says; I saw this man under the power of the Spirit and with my own ears I heard him speak with tongues." It did not occur to him that what he had witnessed might have been the working of Satan, who transforms himself into an angel of light, nor that his personal

[14] Especially women and young people.

observation - and this can often be very deceptive - had led him to pit the experience of a mortal man against the written Word of God.

The same is true of the success stories published about some of the greatest evangelistic efforts of our generation. They are almost always told in the superlative and whatever might not serve to promote the cause further is omitted. The masses swallow these stories whole, but success stories do not prove that such efforts are conducted according to Scripture or are pleasing to God. Thus the apostle exhorts us not to "give heed" to stories but to test all our words and actions by the Word of God, rightly divided.

It is probably by mere stories, even more than by philosophical arguments, that the new evangelicalism has gained such headway in our day. But to the sincere and thoughtful Christian, *both* stories and philosophical arguments must give way before the plain teachings of the Word of God.

Does this sound negative? Then we can only say that the present condition of the Church makes it quite obvious that some negative preaching is badly needed. We are well aware that this is not popular, but we are not trying to be popular; we are trying to help sincere Christians find their way back, step by step, to renewed spiritual power. This power has been too long frittered away by substituting the will of man for the Word of God.

DON'T DOTE ON PERSONALITIES

When Paul further instructs Timothy to charge his followers not to "give heed" to "endless genealogies" (I Tim. 1:4), he refers to the status symbol of the personality cult of his day.

Recently this writer was informed by a correspondent from an eastern state that it appeared that he might be related to a Revolutionary general named Stam - and, did we wish him to investigate further! We replied that we were far too excited about where we were going to care much about where we had come from!

While there are some in our day who are very proud of their ancestry and have coats of arms displayed in their homes, the average Christian probably, has never had his family tree traced back very far. But in Paul's day genealogies were very important, even among the believers. One's family relationships meant a great deal. If you were a second cousin to Christ or even a third cousin to Peter you "had it made." You might be crude and stupid and even wicked, but all this was overlooked: you were closely related to Christ Himself or to the Apostle Peter and all were ready to give you audience.

Actually, the personality cult is still with us in the Church today though it manifests itself in different ways. We live in a day of mass communications, when the faces of prominent men and women are seen again and again in newspapers and magazines and even their personalities come through to us over radio and television. Thus it is the prominent "Christian" politician, athlete, actor, beauty queen, or even former gangster who commands the attention today. Those who arrange evangelistic campaigns often seek to engage such personalities to attract crowds. Such prominent figures, though perhaps actually saved, may be very much "of the world," dishonoring their Christian calling every day, but their presence draws crowds and their shallow testimonies are used to justify their public participation in the work of the Lord.

This too is part of the new evangelicalism, which has borrowed many prominent personalities from the world to help swell its audiences, while the old prayer that the witness may be hid behind the cross is to all intents and purposes considered *passé*.

Let us not be misunderstood here. We heartily thank God for every politician, athlete, actor or even criminal who comes to know Christ as Savior. But conversion alone does not qualify one for a place of prominence in Christian service. This, especially in Paul's epistles, is reserved for mature believers, wholly separated to God and established in the truth (See especially II Tim. 2:21).

When hearts beat faster because of the presence of some glamorous personality on the Christian platform; when such personalities receive adulation which belongs rather to the Christ who died for them, God is dishonored and displeased.

True, the motive in procuring such "crowd-getters" may have been to reach greater numbers for Christ, just as some of our spiritual leaders become yoked together with apostate unbelievers in evangelistic endeavors in order to reach souls for Christ, but the end does not justify the means. It is never right to do wrong to accomplish some good end.

Have we forgotten that God's Word says: *"I the Lord Thy God* am a *jealous*[15] *God"* (Ex. 20:5) and *"I will not give my glory unto another*" (Isa. 48:11)? True we quote here from the ten commandments, but remember, Paul in his epistles quotes all the ten commandments except one (*re* the sabbath). The covenant of the law has been done away but not the moral law itself.

It is time for the Church to realize that salvation is *the work of God* and that true and lasting results will follow only when we conduct His work in His way.

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[15] God Himself is the only Being who has legitimate and urgent reason to be jealous of His glory.

Thus the Word of God *charges* us who would be used of Him in this twentieth century:

Do not change the doctrine to suit the times.

Do not pay attention to stories.

Do not pay homage to personalities.

But to these negatives he adds an important positive**.**

PROCLAIM GOD'S DISPENSATION

We have been told what to avoid in combating the apostasy of the last days; now we are told, at least by clear implication, what *positive* action to take.

Unfortunately the phrase "God's dispensation" (I Tim. 1:4) has been rendered "godly edifying" in our *Authorized Version.* Of the twenty-five translations of the Bible, which we have in our study only two render this phrase "godly edifying." The rest render it *dispensation, administration, divine system, divine plan, ordered way of life, trusteeship, stewardship,* etc., and the word *oikonomia* (dispensation) clearly appears in the Greek.

The point in this passage is that giving heed to stories and glorying in personalities will only serve to stir up questions rather than ministering God's dispensation, and God's dispensation is *the answer* to man's problems in "this present evil age."

Lest any wonder what this dispensation is, we quote the opening words of Ephesians 3:

"For this cause I Paul, the prisoner of Jesus Christ for you Gentiles,

"If ye have heard of THE DISPENSATION OF THE GRACE OF GOD which is given me to you-ward:

"How that by revelation He made known unto me the mystery..." (Eph. 3:1-3).

Since the apostle instructed Timothy to charge some at Ephesus not to teach any other doctrine than that which he had taught, it would be well also to recall his words to the Ephesian elders as he faced persecution and martyrdom.

"But none of these things move me, neither count I my life dear unto myself, so that I might finish my course with joy, and the ministry which I

have received of the Lord Jesus, to testify THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD" (Acts 20:24).

This is the glad news which God would have us dispense to a lost humanity. And this "dispensation of the grace of God" includes far more than salvation from sin. It includes the believer's baptism by the Holy Spirit into Christ and His Body. It includes our heavenly position and blessings and prospect. It includes all "the exceeding riches" of God's grace and power and glory "*to usward*." (See Eph. 1:15-23; *et al*).

Those religious leaders who are striving to establish God's kingdom on earth and are joining hands with the unsaved to bring about social betterment and political reform are *not* cooperating in *God's* program for our day; they are not ministering "God's dispensation," nor are they solving the problems which confront humanity. They are stirring up questions, but not answering them.

Thank God, we have in the epistles of Paul God's answer to man's deepest problems. This answer does *not*, for the present, include the establishment of God's kingdom on earth or the bringing in of social justice. This awaits a future day (Jer. 23:5,6; cf. Rom. 11:25,26). But it does include, for every individual believer in Christ: complete justification from sin (Acts 13:38,39; Rom. 3:24), oneness with Christ in heaven, above the sorrows and troubles of this evil scene (Eph. 2:4-6), "all spiritual blessings in the heavenlies, in Christ" (Eph. 1:3) and the glorious prospect of being caught up to heaven physically in changed and glorified bodies to be forever with Christ (I Thes. 4:15-18; Phil. 3:20,21; Eph. 2:7).

When we consider the hopelessness of the present world situation and observe the futile efforts of some to establish righteousness when the vast majority do not want righteousness; when we think how long the struggle has gone on and realize that according to God's Word it will continue until Christ returns to take the throne; when we consider all this we can see how perfectly the revelation given through Paul by our glorified Lord fits our day and answers our problems, turning curses into blessings and sorrows into joys.

Little wonder the apostle instructed Timothy to *"charge some that they teach no other doctrine."*

Chapter VII

DON'T BE ASHAMED

"Thou hast given a banner to them that fear Thee, that It may be displayed because of the truth."

- Psalm 60:4.

Psalm 60 was written by David while Israel was engaged in a life and death struggle with her surrounding enemies.

God was chastening His people severely because of their unfaithfulness, but a small company, true to Jehovah, was rallying around His banner and was to be delivered (Vers. 4,5). Thus David answers the query of Verse 9 with the confident reply of Verse 12:

"Through God we shall do valiantly, for He it Is that shall tread down our enemies."

Dispensationally this Psalm, like so many others, points forward to "the time of Jacob's trouble," the coming "great tribulation." Its opening verses find Israel "cast off" and "scattered." Soon the earth trembles; Israel is made to drink "the wine of astonishment" because of her apostasy and sin.

But a faithful remnant gathers around a God-given ensign, or banner. That banner is *Christ* (Isa. 11:10). It is God's will that His people *display* this banner, i.e., stand boldly for their Messiah, whom Antichrist and all the world oppose. As they do this they have God's sure promise of victory.

What a lesson for us!

BANNERS TO DISPLAY

If there is one thing that God would have His people do amid the rising apostasy of our day it is to *show their colors.* As the enemy comes in like a flood, even Bible-believing Christians are apt to hide a banner which they should unfurl and boldly display. That banner is *Christ.* How many believers fear to speak up for Him because His name is increasingly despised!

But, as in any war of any size, many and varied flags are carried into battle, this is so in the Christian conflict too, for the Bible, godly living, faithful comrades, etc., are all banners by which we should take our stand, flags we should display.

One such banner is *fundamentalism*, a slogan, a battle cry, which many believers are putting aside and hiding away just when they should display and wave it boldly.

Some, recognizing the spiritual decline among fundamentalists, prefer to be called simply *believers* or *Christians.* We can appreciate this point of view but do not feel it is valid in this time of spiritual crisis.

At a time when the fundamentals of the Christian faith are being threatened as never before, we can do much to show that we stand for these basic doctrines, identifying ourselves openly with them by *calling* ourselves *fundamentalists*. The rapid pace at which the apostasy is rising about us makes it the more urgent that we display this banner. We believe that we have strong Scriptural support for this view.

"I AM A PHARISEE!"

No one knew better than Paul the sins and failures of the Pharisees. He knew how much pride and hypocrisy there was among them. He knew how they "strained at gnats" and "swallowed camels." But he stood with them against the Sadducees. He knew that the Pharisees (Aramaic for *separated*) steadfastly opposed these compromising liberals in their mingling of God-given rites with heathen customs. Even more important, he knew that the Pharisees believed in the supernatural, while the Sadducees, the rationalists of their day, denied it (Acts 23:8). When surrounded by "many infallible proofs" of our Lord's resurrection from the dead, it was not the Pharisees but the Sadducees who still pressed their vicious battle against Him (Acts 4:1,2; 5:17).

Thus, when called before the Sanhedrin, the apostle did not hesitate to take his stand boldly *with* the Pharisees and *against* the Sadducees, crying out:

"Men and brethren, I am a Pharisee, the son of a Pharisee:[16] of the hope and resurrection of the dead I am called in question" (Acts 23:6).

ERASING THE LINE

Some, however, have deliberately *repudiated* the designation *fundamentalist* and have adopted instead the name *evangelical*. Though apparently still conservative in their theology, these champions of the 'new evangelicalism teach that Bible-believing Christians should have fellowship and cooperate with unbelieving apostates to "win souls for Christ." Through their periodicals and books they are endeavoring - with alarming success - to convince sincere

[16] Gr., "a son of Pharisees." He evidently came from a line of Pharisees.

believers that it is pleasing to God to compromise with liberal theologians and with the world. They are deliberately erasing the line of demarcation between fundamentalism and apostasy, and between the Church and the world. They do not wish to bear the reproach of a separated, Bible-believing fundamentalism.

But what does God's Word say about fellowship with apostates?

"If any man teach otherwise, and consent not to wholesome [sound] words, even the words of our Lord Jesus Christ ... FROM SUCH WITHDRAW THYSELF" (I Tim. 6:3-5).

"FOR HE THAT BIDDETH HIM GOD-SPEED IS PARTAKER OF HIS EVIL DEEDS" (II John 11).

And what does God's Word say about fellowship with the world?

"And BE NOT CONFORMED TO THIS WORLD, but be ye transformed by the renewing of your mind, that ye may prove what is that good, and acceptable, and perfect, will of God" (Rom. 12:2).

"Ye adulterers and adulteresses, know ye not that THE FRIENDSHIP OF THE WORLD IS ENMITY WITH GOD? WHOSOEVER THEREFORE WILL BE A FRIEND OF THE WORLD IS THE ENEMY OF GOD" (James 4:4).

Thus James urges his readers to keep themselves "*unspotted from the world"* (James 1:27).

These are not dispensational matters. God's people in every age have been commanded to keep themselves separate from apostasy and from this world system.

FUNDAMENTALISM DOWNGRADED

Much has been said of late about the failures of fundamentalism, and there are many, for God's people today are no less prone to err than was Israel of old. But fundamentalism's very virtues have been downgraded by articles published in several periodicals with an enormous total circulation. These include *Christian Life, Christianity Today, Evangelical Action, Decision* and *Eternity* magazines. Add to these such theological works as Edward J. Carnell's *Case For Orthodoxy,*[17] a significant portion of which is taken up with intemperate abuse of fundamentalists.

[17] Which presents a weak case indeed.

Also such novels as Joe Bayly's *Gospel Blimp,*[18] a satire which pictures Bible-believing fundamentalists as zealous, but so utterly inane as to send a "gospel blimp," not only over a given community, but "flying low" over *one particular home* day after day, motors roaring, loud speakers blaring and dropping "gospel [tract] bombs" to clutter up the lawn and clog the downspouts in the hope of winning the family inside to Christ! But this same book which so recklessly ridicules fundamentalists lauds "those worldly Griscoms," who win their cigarette-smoking, beer-drinking neighbors to Christ by getting "involved" with them, skipping church and going to the shore with them on weekends, thus demonstrating that they are not "holy Joes."

A novel, of course, can always make the desired party successful, but we dare say that the vast majority of converts are won to Christ by those who obey Heb. 10:25, "not *forsaking the assembling of ourselves together, as the manner of some is."* We must prove our love to the lost, to be sure, but one does not win worldlings to Christ by conforming to the world. On the contrary, they must see that we are *different*, that we have something of priceless value which they lack.

But the type of propaganda referred to above is not only subtle; it is so heavily financed and has been so widely disseminated that its sheer volume has overwhelmed many unwary believers, causing them to go along with the crowd, discard the term fundamentalist, and call themselves evangelicals. We beseech such not to let themselves be brainwashed, much less intimidated by the popularity of religious leaders who disobey the Scriptures to cooperate with apostates and dabble in the world to "win souls for Christ."

Is there "a lunatic fringe" among the fundamentalists? Of course! Has there ever been a movement or organization of any size without a lunatic fringe - neo-evangelicalism included? If we are to stop calling ourselves fundamentalists because of a lunatic fringe, we should stop calling ourselves Christians, or believers, or Americans on the same basis.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE TERM FUNDAMENTALIST

Let us consider briefly the significance -- or lack thereof -- of the terms *fundamentalist*, *evangelical* and *conservative*.

The term *evangelical* has little specific significance. It can refer to just about any nominal Christian, whether conservative or liberal, whether true to the faith or heretical.

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[18] Referred to in Chapter VI.

The neo-evangelicals generally also class themselves as conservatives, but this term too has a wide range of reference. Some consider Nelson Rockefeller a political conservative, but we are certain that Ronald Reagan and Barry Goldwater do not! Liberal theologians may look upon neo-evangelicals as conservatives, but many of us feel that the "neos" concede too much, give away too much, to be truly worthy of the name *conservative*.

But the term *fundamentalist* does have a precise meaning. For decades it has referred to those who stand for the fundamentals of the Christian faith. Only recently have communists, liberals - and neo-evangelicals, sought to pervert its simple meaning.

Some point out that there are Mormon "fundamentalists," snake-handling "fundamentalists" and "fundamentalists" in some branches of science. With so many meanings being attached to the word *fundamentalist*, they say, we ought to discard the term and call ourselves evangelicals.

This claim that the word *fundamentalism* has changed its meaning has sent us to several dictionaries lying about here at *Berean Bible Society.* Looking up the word *fundamentalism* we found not one word about Mormons, snake handlers or scientists. Every one of them defined the term in much the same way, as a movement emphasizing the fundamentals of the Christian faith.

Indeed, we have lying before us at this moment the very latest *Random House Dictionary of the English* Language (unabridged). In this dictionary *fundamentalism* is defined thus:

"1*. (sometimes cap*) a movement in American Protestantism that arose in the early part of the 20th century in reaction to modernism and that stresses the inerrancy of the Bible not only in matters of faith and morals but also as a literal historical record, holding as essential to Christian faith belief in such doctrines as the virgin birth, physical resurrection, atonement by the sacrificial death of Christ, and the Second Coming. 2. the beliefs held by those in this movement."

With this definition appearing as the *only* definition of *fundamentalism* in the *very latest* dictionary to be published in America, we urge Bible-believing Christians not to allow the neo-evangelicals and liberals to redefine the word for them. The meaning is clear enough in itself. A *fundamentalist* is one who stands for the fundamentals of the faith, and the term is generally, up to this very date, taken to mean this. Any attempt, therefore, to make it ambiguous or indefinable is pure propaganda which we should ignore unless we want to help those who would minimize the importance of the fundamentals.

ON TWO SIDES OF ONE FENCE

Some neo-evangelicals would be in real trouble if they openly repudiated the designation *fundamentalist,* so they take a cautious position. One such, a president of a Bible college, said to this writer: "I am a fundamentalist in certain circles, as defined in certain ways."

Now, we have no objection to the latter part of this statement. We *should* define our terms. It is the former part to which we object: "I am a fundamentalist *in certain circles*." This is certainly not showing one's colors. Such a policy is, to say the least, inconsistent and is bound to create misunderstanding if not serious distrust. It certainly would not inspire confidence, for one who wishes to be known as a fundamentalist *only in certain circles is* not straddling a fence; he is alternately occupying both sides of a fence. Surely, in circles where fundamentalism has been misrepresented or misunderstood, the faithful Bible believer should *champion* it - *and define it*. When Paul was suspected of vacillating and double dealing, he protested:

"But as God is true, our word toward you was not yea and nay ... but in Him was yea" (II Cor. 1:18,19).

James was of the same mind when he wrote by divine inspiration:

"But let your yea be yea, and your nay, nay, lest ye fall into condemnation" (James 5:12).

DON'T GO HALFWAY

This writer has read several articles by men who "halt between two opinions," dealing with *those phases* of neo-evangelicalism with which they disagree. Such a position is unsatisfactory for two reasons. First, the writer of such an article is almost certain to *miss* one or more unscriptural phases of neo-evangelicalism and his readers may well conclude that he approves of these. Second, when we become involved in important issues arising between one movement which is basically right, and another which is basically wrong, are we not morally obligated to stand *with* the former and *against* the latter?

When modernism arose to discredit Christ and the Bible some decades ago, it would have spelled ruin to oppose only "those phases of modernism" with which we disagreed. Men of God had to oppose modernism *as such.* Of course modernism, like communism and every other false system, taught *some* truth; so does the devil. But when a movement or system is seen to be essentially, basically, subversive of the truth we should take our stand against it. By the same token, when a movement or system is known to stand in defense of the

faith, we should take our stand with it. No man can win the respect of his contemporaries by vacillating here.

A TIME OF CRISIS

One would be blind indeed not to see that we are living in a time of great moral and spiritual crisis; a time when the fundamentals of Christian faith and conduct are being taken ever more lightly. We submit that the desire *not* to be known as a fundamentalist at such a time would be much like *not* wishing to be known as an American at a time when a foreign enemy is invading our land.

During early church history Christians were being mercilessly smeared. They were charged with all sorts of crimes of which they were wholly innocent, and were often threatened with torture and death. Did they thereupon repudiate the designation "Christian" and call themselves by other names because Christianity was so grossly misrepresented? Some doubtless did, but the faithful ones went to the stake and to the lions rather than turn their backs upon their fellow-laborers in the gospel.

In a day when fundamentalism is being threatened by a subtler foe, with a far more subtle approach, let us not desert faithful men of God or be ashamed to be known as *fundamentalists* along with those who *stand* for the fundamentals of the Christian faith. True, the term *fundamentalist* is not found in the Scriptures; neither is many another legitimate word in our Christian vocabulary, but the term does indicate that we stand together in defense of the basic doctrines of Scripture. This is important.

Remember this: If one calls himself a fundamentalist he takes his stand with men who, whatever their failures, believe in the fundamentals of the faith. But if one calls himself an evangelical he takes his stand with many who, whatever their virtues, join in active fellowship with apostates from the faith, with the enemies of God.

"BE NOT ASHAMED ... OF ME"

One further word should be said to those who have come to see the distinctive character of Paul's apostleship and message. These believe not only that "all Scripture is given by inspiration of God" (II Tim. 3:16) but that we must "rightly divide the Word of truth" if we would be "approved unto God .. . workmen who need not to be ashamed" (II Tim. 2:15).

They see clearly that *after* the so-called "great commission" and Pentecost, after the King and His kingdom had been rejected by Israel's rulers, God raised up another apostle, Paul, and sent him forth with another message (See II Cor. 5:14-21; Eph. 3:1-3). They do not confuse prophecy with the great mystery

revealed through Paul (Acts 3:21; Eph. 3:3,8). They do not confuse *"the gospel of the kingdom*" (Luke 9:1-6) with *"the gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24). They do not confuse "the *kingdom of heaven*" (Matt. 13) with *"the body of Christ"* (I Cor. 12:13; Eph. 1:22,23). They do not confuse a Jewish ritual baptism (John 1:31) with our baptism into Christ by "the operation of God" (Rom. 6:3-5; Gal. 3:26,27; Col. 2:9-13; Eph. 4:5). And they do not misinterpret Mark 16:16 and Acts 2:38 to mean what they do not say.

But Satan is greatly disturbed when God's people begin to rightly divide, rightly understand and rightly proclaim the Word of God. Result? Listen to Paul's own testimony:

"Whereunto I am appointed a preacher, and an apostle, and a teacher of the Gentiles.

"FOR THE WHICH CAUSE I ALSO SUFFER THESE THINGS (II Tim. 1:12,12).

"CONSIDER what I say; and the Lord give thee understanding in all things.

"**REMEMBER that Jesus Christ of the seed of David was raised from the dead according to MY GOSPEL:**

"WHEREIN I SUFFER TROUBLE AS AN EVIL DOER, EVEN UNTO BONDS; BUT THE WORD OF GOD IS NOT BOUND" (II Tim. 2:7-9).

Scores of additional passages could be added in which Luke, and Paul himself, bear testimony to the bitterness of the opposition against his God-given message.

The natural temptation, then, especially for one of Timothy's retiring character, would be to withdraw from the fight through fear. Hence the apostle's Spirit-inspired encouragement to him-and to us:

"For GOD HATH NOT GIVEN US THE SPIRIT OF FEAR; BUT OF POWER, AND OF LOVE, AND OF A SOUND MIND.

"BE NOT THOU THEREFORE ASHAMED OF THE TESTIMONY OF OUR LORD, NOR OF ME HIS PRISONER; BUT BE THOU PARTAKER OF THE AFFLICTIONS OF THE GOSPEL ACCORDING TO THE POWER OF GOD" (II Tim. 1:7,8).

"According to the power of God"! What greater encouragement could we desire! With all His might to support us can we do less than stand unashamed

for Christ and for the truth? Indeed, is it not a signal honor to be allowed to participate in *"the fellowship of His sufferings"?* Paul considered it so, and encouraged his followers to consider it so as he wrote:

"FOR UNTO YOU IT IS GIVEN IN THE BEHALF OF CHRIST, NOT ONLY TO BELIEVE ON HIM, BUT ALSO TO SUFFER FOR HIS SAKE;

"HAVING THE SAME CONFLICT WHICH YE SAW IN ME, AND NOW HEAR TO BE IN ME" (Phil. 1:29,30).

Chapter VIII

RELATIVISM IN OUR COLLEGES

The Sept. 2, 1966, issue of *Christianity Today* contained a revealing news item which we would have written about at the time had we not mislaid it! It reads in part as follows:

"'Fifty per cent of chapel services are a waste of time,' declares Dr. Virginia Mollenkott, head of the English Department of *Nyack* (New York) *Missionary College.* She says they are frequently 'exercises in naiveté' during which students prefer to study and write letters. 'The students turn off their hearing aids when someone starts preaching in absolutes.'

"At Nyack, leading school of the *Christian and Missionary Alliance*, the faculty is said to be more avant-garde than the student body. On most campuses it's the other way around."

If the faculty at *Nyack Missionary College* is as avant-garde as indicated, you may write it down that still another Christian College has gone down the neo-evangelical drain. In that case they are to blame if "the students turn off their hearing aids when someone starts preaching in absolutes." Too many religious leaders have left the powerful absolutes of God's Word to teach the relativism of modern philosophy. Nothing can be fully depended upon except perhaps the Bible, and then only in a general sort of way, for everyone interprets it differently! So nothing really is absolute - all is relative!

Little wonder so many are pressing for dialogue rather than monologue, for general discussion rather than a positive message delivered by a man who has been called of God and convicted of the truth of His Word.

This emphasis on the relative, this call for dialogue by religious leaders betrays their spiritual bankruptcy and their lack of Biblical knowledge and conviction. They do not immerse themselves in that blessed Book as did the great Bible teachers of a generation ago. They are not filled with a burning desire to convey its message to others. Little wonder they prefer dialogue to monologue.

This we know: If Sir Winston Churchill were to deign to enlighten us on statesmanship, we would not wish to discuss it with him; we would just want to sit and listen. But as the above news item goes on to say:

"Perhaps the most serious aspect of the current unsettledness is that so few are aware of it among the constituency - namely, the financial supporters of the

college, the parents of the students, and the general membership of the sponsoring churches. College administrators almost invariably try to keep the lid on controversial rumblings, fearing that if word gets out the sources of college revenue will be threatened. The resulting information gap makes for an explosive potential."

LITTLE FOXES AND A LITTLE LEAVEN

Many Christian people entertain the notion that apostasy from the truth begins with a denial of one or more of the fundamentals of the faith, such as the infallibility of the Bible, the deity of Christ, or the efficacy of His redemptive work. The moral aspect of apostasy, they suppose, comes about in much the same way.

This view is not wholly correct, for apostasy generally *begins*, not with holding, but with *condoning* spiritual or moral error.

Eve fell into sin, not by denying what God had said but by *listening* to Satan.

THE LITTLE FOXES THAT SPOIL THE VINES

In the Song of Solomon, the Shulamite damsel, doubtless quoting the words of Solomon, her beloved bridegroom, notes that the vineyards are in full blossom. Soon the grapes will be ripe for the marriage feast. But a danger threatens the harvest: "*the foxes, the little foxes that spoil the vines."* These must without fail be "taken," or *caught* (Song of Solomon 2:15).

What a striking lesson we have here! How often God's people have stood at the threshold of great blessing, the refreshing odor of an abundant spiritual harvest in the air when, alas, all has been lost - not through a frontal attack by the adversary, but by those wily little foxes that had been permitted to spoil the vines. Some doctrine or practice, clearly unscriptural and subversive of spiritual blessing, had been condoned when, like the little foxes of Solomon's song, they should have been caught and disposed of.

A LITTLE LEAVEN AND LOST BLESSING

It is difficult, if not impossible, to determine from Paul's Epistle to the Galatians, just what the Galatian believers thought the rite of circumcision would accomplish for them spiritually. We doubt that they knew themselves, but the Judaizers had come in among them and had captured their attention so that these, who had been so gloriously saved by grace, now "desired to be under the law" (Gal. 4:21). They did not deny the efficacy of the finished work of Christ, but they were interested - just interested - in submitting to a religious ceremony which would in itself be a denial of the all-sufficiency of His

redemptive work (3:1; 5:2-4). Result: the blessing was already vanishing (4:15) and the apostle had to warn them: "*A little leaven leaveneth the whole lump*" (5:9). You can't admit a little leaven and expect it to stop there.

With the Corinthians it was rather a case of countenancing *moral* wrong. One of their members had been living in grievous sin. But then, their number was large, and he was just one, and the congregation as a whole abounded in spiritual gifts. Feeling quite satisfied with themselves, therefore, they simply overlooked this disgrace to the name of Christ. But listen to Paul's - God's - view of the matter:

"And ye are puffed up, and have not rather mourned, that he that hath done this deed might be taken away from among you" (I Cor. 5:2).

"Your glorying is not good. Know ye not that a little leaven leaveneth the whole lump?

"Purge out therefore the old leaven (Verses 6,7).

THE PATH TO RESTORATION

In these days when both spiritual error and moral wrong are made so palatable, when apostate unbelief and worldliness are presented so appetizingly, we do well to take heed to the Spirit's warning to quickly purge out the "little leaven" that threatens to permeate the whole loaf.

Already many Bible-believing churches and organizations that once knew the power and joy of the Spirit have condoned too much. Already the apostle's question could appropriately be asked of them: "Where is then the blessedness ye spake of?"

This blessedness cannot be restored by any amount of mere praying or planning. Resolute action must be taken. Those little foxes must be caught and dispatched. The "little leaven" must be purged out.

Chapter IX

THE POWER OF GODLINESS

St. Paul's last epistle includes a warning that in the last days of this present dispensation of grace many will have "*a form of godliness, but denying the power thereof"* (II Tim. 3:5).

The meaning of the word *godliness* here is clear enough, for in the twenty-three passages of the New Testament where the original word is found in one or another of its grammatical forms, it is variously translated *holy, pious, devout* and *godly*.

THE MYSTERY OF LAWLESSNESS

Referring to the apostasy which was to find its culmination in the "great tribulation," the apostle had written to the Thessalonians: *"For the mystery of iniquity [lawlessness] doth already work*" (II Thes. 2:7).

Subtly, but effectively, a spirit of rebellion against authority, especially divine authority, was already at work in his day. Now, in our day, we see this phenomenon greatly intensified.

We are perhaps too apt to conclude that some current subversive movement is behind the present trend away from God and His Word, for God Himself informs us that it is Satan and his angels who work mysteriously behind the scenes to instill this spirit of lawlessness.

Satan and his host of "wicked spirits in the heavenlies" are "the rulers of the darkness of this age" (Eph. 6:12). It is he who "now worketh in the children of disobedience" (Eph. 2:2) and whose human personification will one day reign over this Christ-rejecting world as Antichrist (II Thes. 2:3-12).

THE MYSTERY OF GODLINESS

But over against "the mystery of *lawlessness"* there is "the mystery of *godliness,"* also working mysteriously but effectively, for, says the apostle, "*without controversy great is the mystery of godliness"*[19] (I Tim. 3:16).

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[19] It has been much debated whether the word God appears in the original as the next word in this verse. Some have rendered this word "*which*" rather than "*God*." In either case we do not believe that this passage refers to the incarnation of Christ. *Godliness* is indeed *God manifested in the flesh*, *i.e.*, in human beings. But it was not our Lord's flesh that manifested Him as God. His flesh is rather said to have *veiled* the divine presence (Heb. 10:19,20). Furthermore, our Lord was “preached unto the Gentiles”

True godliness manifested in the life of the believer may be despised by the world but it is *"justified in [by] the Spirit."* Moreover, this godliness in a wicked world is wonderingly *"seen of angels"* even as it is "*preached unto the Gentiles"* and *"believed on in the world."* Finally it will be *"received up into glory*" with the members of Christ's Body before God speaks to this rebellious world in His wrath.

This "mystery of godliness" in a godless, lawless world is indeed a remarkable phenomenon to behold, for, standing against the swelling tide of this whole world-system there are millions, scattered all over the earth, who worship God and love and trust His blessed Son. St. Peter writes of this so beautifully:

"Whom having not seen, ye love; in whom, though now ye see Him not, yet believing, ye rejoice with joy unspeakable and full of glory" (I Pet. 1:8).

All this is lacking in the lives of the religious apostates of our day. The Apostle Paul predicted by divine inspiration that they would have much to say about religion and God, "*having a form of godliness, but denying the power thereof"* (II Tim. 3:5). That is, while they go through all the formalities, their *lives* do not evidence *the power of godliness.*

THE POWER OF GODLINESS

God would have us live as His own sacred possession, separate from this world-system, but godliness is out of style these days. Religious leaders in ever greater number are telling us that to win the world we must become part of it and to win the people of the world we must have fellowship with them in the things they do and the places to which they go. But the believer cannot impress the world by conforming to it. And even *if he could* this approach would still be *contrary to the Will of God,* for His Word exhorts us:

"BE NOT CONFORMED TO THIS WORLD, BUT BE YE TRANSFORMED BY THE RENEWING OF YOUR MIND, THAT YE MAY PROVE WHAT IS THAT GOOD, AND ACCEPRABLE, AND PERFECT, WILL OF GOD" (Rom. 12:2).

It is true godliness, consistent separation to God from this world, which most deeply impresses the lost to whom we bear witness.

True godliness exerts enormous spiritual power. It causes men to toil and sacrifice, yea to suffer and die for Christ and for others. It exerts a profound influence upon those with whom it comes into contact. A truly godly believer will win the respect of other believers and by his example encourage them to live

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long *after* He was "received up into glory." When the subject here is seen to be *godliness"* rather than the incarnation of Christ, however, all is in proper order.

godly lives, while his godliness will convict the lost, so that they will either be angered or will turn to Christ for salvation.

This is why II Tim. 3:12 says*: "Yea, and all that will live godly in Christ Jesus shall suffer persecution."* Carnal Christians do not like to think about the word "*all*" in this passage, but it is there and stands as a rebuke to their lack of consecration to God.

The Scriptures, especially Paul's epistles, have much to say about "*the doctrine which is according to [consistent with*] *godliness"* (I Tim. 6:3) and *"the truth which is after [productive of] godliness"* (Tit. 1:1). Though his epistles comprise less than one-third of the text of the so-called New Testament, thirteen of the twenty-three New Testament occurrences of the word *godly* are found in his epistles. Indeed, the truth about godliness is God's message through Paul to us especially for "this present evil age" and more especially for the "perilous times" of these "last days."

Knowing "the power of godliness," the apostle exhorts us to live our lives "*in all godliness and* hon*esty"* (I Tim. 2:2), to *"exercise," or discipline* ourselves "unto *godliness"* (I Tim. 4:7), to "flee" sin but *"follow after* ... *godliness"* (I Tim. 6:11).

"For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men,

"Teaching us that, denying ungodliness and worldly lusts, we should live soberly, righteously, and godly, In this present world;

"Looking for that blessed hope, and the glorious appearing of the great God and our Savior Jesus Christ;

"Who gave Himself for us, that He might redeem us from all Iniquity, and purify unto Himself a peculiar [separated] people, zealous of good works" (Tit. 2:11-14).

God help us! and grant that "the power of godliness" may be evident in our relationship with all those with whom we come into contact; that through our influence the lost may be saved and our fellow-believers encouraged, strengthened and inspired to stand true to God in these last perilous days of "this present evil age."

Chapter X

PREACH THE WORD

Paul's last recorded words are of profound importance to every believer. They constitute the farewell instructions and exhortations of a great and faithful soldier of Jesus Christ to his first lieutenant, who must now carry on in his place.

The apostle had laboured and sacrificed and fought and suffered to proclaim "the gospel of the grace of God" in all its purity and was now about to die by the sword as a martyr for Christ. How solemn, then, is his mandate:

"I charge thee therefore before God, and the Lord Jesus Christ, who shall judge the quick and the dead at His appearing and His kingdom;

"Preach the Word; be instant in season, out of season; reprove, rebuke, exhort with all longsuffering and doctrine" (II Tim. 4:1,2).

But this is not only Paul's word to Timothy; it is also God's Word to us. The solemn order to Timothy to "*preach the Word"* and to carry on his ministry "with all longsuffering *and doctrine*," was thus given because the Spirit-inspired apostle saw in advance the very conditions which prevail in our day:

"For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine; but after their own lusts [desires] shall they heap to themselves teachers, having itching ears;

"And they shall turn away their ears from the truth, and shall be turned unto fables" (Vers. 3,4).

A BETTER WAY?

There are those in our day who feel that they know a better approach, a better way to hold the interest of the saved and to reach the unsaved for Christ. Their argument runs this way: Since we appear to be in the last days, when so many "will not endure sound doctrine" and "turn away their ears from the truth," we must use a more subtle approach to reach them than merely proclaiming the Word of God. We must find out what *they* like and give it to them and *then* get our testimony to them.

And thus entertainment and the Word of God are offered on the same platter, as it were, so that the one vitiates the other. Moreover the spiritual health of the believer is thus impaired for he now becomes accustomed to a

lighter diet and begins to *need* entertainment to keep him interested. And now the church is caught in a vicious cycle, for, depend upon it, if you use entertainment as a means to fill your auditorium you will continually have to offer more and livelier entertainment to *keep* it filled - and in this competition with the world the Church must necessarily come out as the loser.

INTELLECTUALISM THE ANSWER?

Another argument currently advanced is that since increasing numbers are turning away from the Scriptures for intellectual reasons we must persuade them with philosophical and scientific arguments that the Bible is the Word of God. Intellectualism is the watchword today. If you are not intellectual you are nothing. Thus many pastors spend more time trying to be intellectual than studying and preaching the Word.

But merely convincing men intellectually that the Bible is "inspired of God" will not save their souls. There are multitudes of intellectual "believers" who are nevertheless lost. Even in our Lord's day there were those who, like Nicodemus, gave mental assent that He was "a teacher come from God," but He "did not commit Himself unto them" because He knew that they needed to be *born again* (See John 2:23-3:7).

We emphasize the fact that II Timothy 4 concerns the closing days of the dispensation of grace and it is *with these days in view* that the solemn charge is uttered: *"Preach the Word."* The Word is "the Sword of the Spirit," which pierces the human facade, the "discerner of the thoughts and intents [motives] of the heart" which convicts the self-righteous and causes them to cry to God for help. It is by the *Word* that sons of Adam are born again to become the sons of God. It is the *Word* that nourishes the hungry and gives light to those in darkness.

GOD'S WORD TO US TODAY

One word of caution: In charging Timothy to "preach the Word," the apostle does not mean, as some have supposed, that the pastor should draw his sermon material equally from all parts of the Bible. True, "*all* Scripture" is given so that the "man of God" may be fully equipped for his ministry. But in this same letter the Apostle Paul indicates that the Scriptures must be "rightly divided" (II Tim. 2:15) and that *his own* God-given message is the Word of God in particular for the present dispensation of grace (See II Tim. 1:7-14; 2:7-9).

This glorious message committed to the Apostle Paul is called in II Cor. 5:19 "the word of reconciliation," in Phil. 2:16 "the word of life," in Col. 1:5 "the word of truth," in Col. 3:16 "the word of Christ," and the apostle declares by inspiration that believers are established by *"my gospel and the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the my*stery" (Rom. 16:25).

How often the apostle insists that his message is the Word of God! To the Thessalonian believers he writes with joy:

"For this cause also thank we God without ceasing, because, when ye received the Word of God which ye heard of us, ye received it not as the word of men, but as it is In truth, the Word of God . . ." (I Thes. 2:13).

Thus the apostle writes to Timothy, in this his last letter:

"Hold fast the form of sound words which thou hast heard of me ... " (II Tim. 1:13).

"And the things that thou hast heard of me among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men ... " (2:2).

"Remember that Jesus Christ, of the seed of David, was raised from the dead according to my gospel" (2:8).

The charge to "preach the Word," therefore, refers to "all Scripture" in general, but to *Paul's God-given message in particular*. This is obvious, for it is in urging Timothy to faithfully carry on *in his place* that the apostle charges him to "preach the Word." Thus to be thoroughly familiar with the *law*, the *history*, the *Psalms* and the *prophecy* of the Scriptures, but confused as to the mighty message proclaimed in Paul's epistles, is still to fail to preach the Word as "a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the Word of truth" (II Tim. 2:15).

Chapter XI

DO THE WORK OF AN EVANGELIST

MAKE FULL PROOF OF YOUR MINISTRY

Paul's farewell exhortations to Timothy were written with great urgency. The time of the apostle's departure by cruel martyrdom was now at hand and ere long his testimony would be sealed with his life's blood. It was with this in view that, rather than thinking of himself or now simply "leaving everything with the Lord," he kept still planning for the future, still occupied with the ministry which the glorified Lord had committed to him many years previous. There was still so much to be done, so many souls to be won and Timothy must now carry on the work with renewed vigor. Thus it is that we read in II Tim. 4:5:

"But watch thou in all things, endure afflictions, do the work of an evangelist, make full proof of thy ministry."

EVANGELISTS MUST TEACH THE WORD

There is much confusion about evangelism these days.

First, there are some who have concluded from Eph. 4:11 that the evangelist necessarily belongs to a different category from "pastors and teachers," or "teaching pastors." It is true that according to this verse some of God's servants are specially gifted and specially productive as evangelists, but have we read too much into this passage?

Some have read into it that the evangelist need not be a teacher of the Word. He need not be well grounded in the Scriptures if only he can tell people that Christ died for their sins. This reminds us of the converted performer who, contrary to I Tim. 5:22, was immediately pushed forward by Christian leaders as an evangelist. It cost heavily to secure his services, but it was worth it; *he could get crowds!* He was barely grounded in the Scriptures, but what matter? He had such a way with him; he could tell such interesting stories and had written several popular gospel songs. He was able to induce many hearers to make "decisions" for Christ just because he had come to the pulpit straight from show business. To quote his own words: "I leave doctrine to the theologians. I preach Christ."

But the question immediately arises: "Christ Who?" "Which Christ?" It makes a great difference whether one preaches the Christ of Palestine or the glorified Christ proclaimed by Paul. And it makes a greater difference whether he preaches the Christ of liberalism or the Christ of the Bible.

A similar notion prevails that foreign missionaries (also actually evangelists) need not be thoroughly grounded in the Word to do justice to their ministries. But all this is unscriptural and wrong, and the churches established by such missionaries *cannot* be spiritually strong.

St. Paul was doubtless the greatest evangelist that ever lived and *he* won the lost to Christ by *teaching* the great doctrines of alienation, reconciliation, justification, etc. And today the evangelist, no less than any minister of God, must be well grounded in the Word, for souls are saved and established *only as the Spirit uses the Word* (I Pet. 1:23-25).

Thus the proclamation of the gospel is not to be separated from the teaching of the Word. Those who are saved - and many are *not* truly saved - through hearing no more than a verse or two from Scripture presented along with an emotional and psychological appeal, are often easily swayed and must at best be spiritually weak. But when the great doctrines of salvation are *taught* from the Scriptures those who hear and believe begin already to be established in the faith. Nor will they be easily shaken, for nothing so grips the heart of man like the Word *understood* and *believed*. This writer will never cease to thank God that he was saved through the *teaching* of the Word. One blessed result of this is that never once since that day, forty-six years ago, has he ever doubted his eternal security in Christ.

BIBLE TEACHERS MUST BE EVANGELISTS

To look at this subject from the other side, there are some who suppose that the pastor or Bible teacher need not be an evangelist. He can always have gospel literature ready to hand to interested persons and can from time to time call in evangelists for special services. As one pastor said to this writer: "Some of us simply are not evangelists and we should not try to be." But the pastor was wrong, dead wrong, for as we have seen, Paul wrote to Timothy, the pastor and Bible teacher at Ephesus: "*Do the work of an evangelist; make full proof of thy ministry."*

Does not this clearly imply that the pastor, the Bible teacher, who does *not* do the work of an evangelist is *deficient* in his ministry? For one thing, such a pastor shows a shameful lack of concern for the lost, for he fails to press home to the hearts of his unsaved hearers the urgency of many of the very Scripture truths which he discusses in his sermons. For another thing, he disobeys God, who says: "*Do the work of an evangelist,"* indeed, who has committed to us all "the ministry of reconciliation" to be fulfilled as "the love of Christ constraineth us" (II Cor. 5:14-21).

If pastors and Bible teachers were more faithful in doing "the work of an evangelist," the general public would not be so readily taken in by the un-scriptural and God-dishonoring methods of evangelism so popular in our day, methods which create much interest and make good statistics but also do much to confuse both the lost and the saved and to make void the Word of God.

EVERY MAN EVANGELISM

Finally, does not Paul's Spirit-inspired injunction apply indirectly to *every* believer in Christ? Are not our pastors simply our *leaders* in the work of the Lord? Shall the congregation sit idly by as the pastor alone does "the work of an evangelist?" God forbid! The pastor is rather to be an example to his flock to go and do likewise.

How well this writer recalls the days of the so-called Darby-Scofield movement when multitudes all over the country thronged to hear Bible teachers like Gaebelein, Gray, Gregg, Ottman, Chafer and Newell. These able men of God expounded the Word as the "blessed hope" of the Lord's return was being recovered. But these Bible teachers were evangelists too, in the truest sense of the word, and their evangelism was contagious.

In those days almost all premillenarians, including the young people, carried New Testaments in their pockets wherever they went. Why? They hoped and prayed for opportunities to testify to others about God's plan of salvation through Christ and they wanted to *show* them the way *from Scripture*. In those days if a Christian failed to have a New Testament with him he was apt to be reproved with the words: "*What*, *a soldier without a sword!"* By contrast few believers carry New Testaments about with them today, and they certainly don't carry Bibles! Here at *Berean Bible Society* we still sell many Bibles for use at home and church, but few New Testaments.

Some are telling us today that this brand of fundamentalism is out of date and ineffective in these fast-changing times. We reply that all of us ought to get back to this brand of fundamentalism, this earnest effort to personally win souls to Christ by showing them God's plan of salvation *from the Scriptures.*

God help his people in general and our spiritual leaders in particular, to "do the work of an evangelist."

Chapter XII

THE EPIPHANY OF GRACE

"For the grace of God that bringeth salvation hath appeared to all men."

- Titus 2: 11.

THE GREATEST REVELATION OF ALL TIME

To the Apostle Paul was committed the greatest revelation of all time: "*the mystery,*" the secret of the gospel and of God's eternal purpose (Col. 1:25,26). To him was entrusted *"the dispensation of the grace of God"* (Eph. 3:1-3). His ministry superseded that of Peter and the eleven as, upon Israel's continued rejection of Christ and His kingdom, he became the apostle to the nations (Rom. 11:13). Solemn recognition was given to this fact by the leaders of the twelve (including Peter himself) as they gave to Paul and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship, acknowledging Paul's divine commission to go to the Gentiles, and agreeing thenceforth to confine their own ministry to Israel (Gal. 2:2,7,9).

In connection with this commission Paul was also the divinely appointed minister of the Church of the present dispensation, *"the Body of Christ"*[20] (Col. 1:24,25). No other Bible writer has one single word to say about "the Church which is [Christ's] Body." None of the other apostles mentions it. Not only would we seek in vain for such *phraseology* in their writings, but we would seek in vain for any discussion of the *subject, f*or they do not discuss the Church of which believers today are members. But Paul, who wrote more of the books of the Bible than any other writer, deals consistently with those truths which concern "the Church which is His Body" (Eph. 1:19-23).

THE REVELATION LOST TO THE CHURCH

But this great revelation and the glorious truths associated with it have been largely lost to the professing Church.

The Church of Rome ignores the facts we have stated above though they are clearly set forth in her own translations of the Bible. She insists that the true Church of today is a perpetuation of that which was founded by Christ while on earth; *a kingdom* to be established *on earth*, over which Peter and the eleven

[20] Composed of Jews and Gentiles reconciled to God in *one body* by the *cross* (Eph. 2:14-16: 1 Cor. 12:13), as compared with the *kingdom* church, which had the *throne* of Christ in view (See Matt. 16:15-18: 19:28; Acts 1:6; 3:19-21).

were appointed to be heads and rulers during His absence. And even though our Lord said nothing about a *prolonged* absence or of any *succession of* such rulers, Rome declares that her present pope is a successor to Peter and, as such, the Vicar of Christ and supreme Head of the Church on earth. Consistent with this she holds that she is laboring to fulfill the "great commission" given to Peter and the eleven, requiring water baptism for the remission of sins and claiming to possess miraculous powers.

But Protestantism, while boasting freedom from the tyranny of Rome, has by no means emerged entirely from the shadows of the dark ages. She still suffers a Roman hangover. While renouncing papal authority, she nevertheless still clings to the Roman teaching that the Church of today is a perpetuation of that to which our Lord referred in Matt. 16:16-18 and that it *is* God's kingdom on earth. She too seeks to carry out the "great commission" given to Peter and the eleven, though halfheartedly, for she cannot make up her mind whether water baptism is or is not necessary to the remission of sins and is also confused and disagreed as to whether or not she possesses the miraculous power of the "great commission."

Martin Luther, under God, shook Europe to its foundations with a partial recovery of Pauline truth, but the Protestant Church has done little to further that recovery, so that rather than recognizing the distinctive character of Paul's position as *our* apostle, most Protestants think of him simply as *one of the apostles,* along with Peter and the eleven. In taking so short a step away from Rome the Protestant Church has assumed a very weak position, for if Paul is to be considered as one with the twelve, Rome can easily prove that *Peter*, not Paul, was appointed as their chief (See Matt. 16:19; Acts 1:15; 2:14,38; 5:29, etc.) [21]

Since Christendom has strayed so far and so long from the great Pauline revelation she has lost sight almost completely of the vastness of his ministry and influence and the extent to which his message once became known in the world. An example of this is found in what Bible scholars have done with Titus 2:11.

It is generally - and correctly - agreed that the *epiphaneia* in this passage connotes a *conspicuous* or *illustrious* appearing, a *shining forth* and that the phrase "*all men*" therefore does not signify each individual singly, but all men collectively; *all mankind*. But few can quite believe that even under Paul's ministry the gospel of God's grace shone forth to all mankind, that its proclamation ever became worldwide in scope. They conclude that Paul could not have meant this; that he *must* have meant only that the grace of God, *bringing salvation for all*, had appeared.

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[21] See the writer's books: *The Apostolic Authority of the Twelve* and *Paul the Master-builder*.

This problem seems to have troubled even the translators of this passage, for Bible translators have never been agreed as to its true meaning.

According to some translations, like Darby's *New Translation*, the apostle meant that the grace of God had appeared, *bringing salvation for all men*. According to others, like the *Authorized* (quoted above) he meant that the grace of God had *appeared to all men*, bringing salvation. Still others use guarded phraseology, even to the point of ambiguity, but most take one or the other of the views above. The majority, probably, including some of those apt to be most *faithful* in their renderings, conform in substance to the *Authorized Version* as quoted above. One cannot help feeling that were it not for the translators' doubts that Paul *could* have meant that the message of grace had shone forth to all mankind, all or nearly all, would have rendered the passage substantially like the Authorized. In view of these doubts it is significant that so many *have* rendered it like the *Authorized.*

THE TWELVE AND THEIR COMMISSION

Apart from Paul's statement in Tit. 2:11 there is much Scriptural evidence that his message *did* shine forth to all the known world. Before considering this evidence, however, let us first observe that the eleven, under Peter, had previously been sent to proclaim their God-given message to all mankind. In the records of their "great commission" three different terms are used to emphasize this fact:

"Go ye therefore, and teach [make disciples of] ALL NATIONS" (Matt. 28:29; cf. Luke 24:47).

"Go ye Into ALL THE WORLD, and preach the gospel to EVERY CREATURE [i.e., ALL CREATION]" (Mark 16:15).

The reader is asked to remember well these three terms: *all nations, all the world* and *all creation*, for we are to find them used again in connection with the ministry of Paul.

The twelve (Matthias replacing Judas) *began* to carry out their world-wide mission, but never got beyond their own nation. We should always associate Acts 1:8 with Acts 8:1 in our study of the Acts, for Jerusalem, rather than turning to Messiah, so that the apostles could go on with their "great commission," started a "great persecution" against the Church there, with the result that *"they were all scattered abroad throughout the regions of Judaea ,and Samaria, except the apostles."*

The twelve have often been charged with bigotry and unfaithfulness for remaining at Jerusalem at this time. In fact, however, it was rare courage and fidelity to their commission that kept them in Jerusalem while persecution raged and their very lives were in danger. They remained at Jerusalem for the same reason that the rest fled: because Jerusalem was *not* turning to Christ. The first part of their commission had not yet been fulfilled, therefore they were duty-bound to remain there.

The twelve did not remain at Jerusalem because they were prejudiced against the salvation of the Gentiles. There is too much Scriptural evidence against this. They remained there because they had a clear understanding of the prophetic program and of their Lord's commission (See Luke 24:45; Acts 1:3; 2:4). They knew that according to covenant and prophecy the Gentiles were to be saved and blessed *through redeemed Israel* (Gen. 22:17,18; Isa. 60:1-3; Zech. 8:13). Our Lord had indicated no change in this program. He worked in perfect harmony with it. Even before His death He had insisted that Israel was *first* in God's revealed program, commanding His disciples not to go to the Gentiles or to the Samaritans but to *"go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel"* (Matt. 10:6), and saying to a Gentile who came for help: *"Let the children first be filled*" (Mark 7:27). And later, in His "great commission" to the eleven, He had specifically stated that they should *begin at Jerusalem* (Luke 24:47; Acts 1:8).

Peter certainly indicated his desire that the commission under which he worked would bring about the fulfillment of the prophecies and the covenant to Abraham, when he said to the "men of Israel":

"Ye are the children of the prophets, and of the covenant which God made with our fathers, saying unto Abraham, and IN THY SEED shall all the kindreds of the earth be blessed.

"UNTO YOU FIRST God, having raised up His Son Jesus, sent Him to bless you, In turning away every one of you from his Iniquities" (Acts 3:25,26).

And Paul, though not working under this same commission, later also bore witness that Israel had been first in God's program, when he said to the Jews at Pisidian Antioch:

"IT WAS NECESSARY THAT THE WORD OF GOD SHOULD FIRST HAVE BEEN SPOKEN TO YOU" (Acts 13:46).

It was only because Israel persisted in rejecting Christ and His Kingdom that God began to set the nation aside, raising up Paul to go to the Gentiles with the good news of salvation "by grace," apart from the covenants and prophecies,

and "through faith," apart from works. It was then that Paul went to Jerusalem "by revelation" and communicated to the leaders there that gospel which he preached among the Gentiles (Gal. 2:2). And those leaders, including Peter himself, gave to Paul and Barnabas the right hands of fellowship in official recognition of the fact that *Paul* had been chosen by Christ as the apostle to the nations and that they were henceforth to confine their ministry to Israel (Gal. 2:7-9).

With this official recognition of the divine purpose the apostles at Jerusalem were "loosed" from their original commission to make disciples of all nations, and Paul alone could say:

"**I speak to you Gentiles, inasmuch as I am the apostle of the Gentiles, I magnify mine office" (Rom. 11:23).**

Arguments are sometimes presented from church history to prove that the twelve did go to Gentile territory; that not more than one or two of them died in Palestine. But even if these arguments could be fully substantiated, this would not enter into the case, for whatever the Circumcision apostles may have done after the agreement of Gal. 2, *they had no apostolic authority among the Gentiles,* and after the declaration of Acts 28:28 they had *no apostolic authority whatever*. What any of them wrote (of the Scriptures) after that, they simply wrote by inspiration of the Holy Spirit, just as any other Bible writer.

Let us mark well, then, that Peter and the eleven, who had originally been sent to proclaim the gospel of the kingdom to "all nations," "all the world" and "all creation," *never completed their mission*. Indeed, had they done so that dispensation would have been brought to a close, for our Lord had said concerning the tribulation period (then imminent, but later graciously postponed):

"And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; AND THEN SHALL THE END COME" (Matt. 24:14).

If, therefore, the pouring out of the Spirit had been followed directly by the pouring out of God's wrath (both predicted in Joel 2 as quoted by Peter in Acts 2) Israel would have turned to God in repentance and the twelve would have proceeded to proclaim "the gospel of the kingdom" to all nations. That dispensation would thus have been consummated; the end would have come. But rather than send the judgment immediately, God interrupted the prophetic program and revealed His secret purpose, sending Paul forth to proclaim to all mankind "the *gospel of the grace of God"* (Acts 20:24).

PAUL AND HIS COMMISSION

Surely no one even superficially acquainted with the Book of Acts or the Epistles of Paul will question the fact that sometime *after* our Lord's commission to the eleven, *Paul* was sent, as an apostle of Christ, to proclaim to all mankind "the gospel of the grace of God."

It is significant that the three terms employed in the so-called "great commission" to indicate its world-wide scope, are also used in Paul's epistles in connection with *his* ministry. Only, whereas the twelve never got to "*all nations," "all the world"* or "all creation" with their message, Paul *did* with his.

In closing his epistle to the Romans the apostle says:

"Now to Him that is of power to establish you according to my gospel, and the preaching of Jesus Christ according to the revelation of the mystery, which was kept secret since the world began.

"BUT NOW IS MADE MANIFEST, AND by the Scriptures of the prophets,[22] according to the commandment of the everlasting God, MADE KNOWN TO ALL NATIONS for the obedience of faith" (Rom. 16:25,26).

And to the Colossians he writes concerning "*the truth of the gospel":*

"WHICH IS COME UNTO YOU, AS IT IS IN ALL THE WORLD; and bringeth forth fruit, as it doth also In you (Col. 1:6).

". . . which ye have heard, and WHICH WAS PREACHED TO EVERY CREATURE WHICH IS UNDER HEAVEN [ALL CREATION UNDER HEAVEN]; whereof I Paul am made a minister (Col. 1:23).

Various arguments may be advanced to prove that "the gospel of the grace of God" did not actually reach "all the world" or "all creation," and we do not deny that to those addressed "all the world" would doubtless mean all the *known* world, and "all creation" would likewise mean all the creation *as they knew it.* But the point is that whatever these three phrases mean in the so-called "great commission," they must also mean in these statements by Paul, for the terms are exactly identical in the original.

We have seen how the twelve did *not* get their message to "all nations..... all the world" or "all creation," because, on the one hand Israel rejected it and on the other hand God had a secret purpose to unfold. But Paul, to whom this

[22] Lit., prophetic writings, i.e., his own writings, for it had been "*kept secret*" and was only "*now*" made manifest.

secret purpose was revealed, says he *did* get *his* message to "all nations," "all the world" and "all creation."

Whereas the twelve never got beyond their own nation in carrying out their commission, it is written of Paul that during his stay at Ephesus "*all they which dwelt in Asia* [a province of Asia Minor] heard *the word of the Lord Jesus"* (Acts 19:10). To the Romans he writes*: "from Jerusalem, and round about unto Illyricum, I have fully preached the gospel of Christ"* (Rom. 15:19), and speaks of his plans to go to Spain (15:24), plans which may well have been accomplished. Even of his helpers it was said: *"These that have turned the world upside down are come hither also"* (Acts 17:6). And to the Romans again he says: "*your faith is spoken of throughout the whole world"* (Rom. 1:8).

With regard to this last statement it is argued by some that since Paul had not even been to Rome by then, it must be that believers from the Jerusalem Church got as far as Rome under their "great commission."

We do not accept this as valid, for we read in Acts 8:1 that in the great persecution in Jerusalem "they were all scattered abroad throughout *the regions of Judaea and Samaria*, except the apostles." Then, with regard to this same scattering we read further:

"They therefore that were scattered abroad upon the tribulation that arose about Stephen travelled AS FAR AS Phoenicia, and Cyprus, and Antioch, speaking the word to none save ONLY TO JEWS.

"But there were SOME of them, men of Cyprus and Cyrene, who, when they were come to ANTIOCH, spake UNTO THE GREEKS ALSO, preaching the Lord Jesus (Acts 11:19,20; R.V.).

But when the Church at Jerusalem heard of this they sent Barnabas to look into it and *he* went to Tarsus to find *Saul* (later called *Paul*), and under Saul the Church at Antioch became the base of operations for the evangelization of the *Gentiles* with "the gospel of the grace of God."

It was from Antioch that Paul went by revelation to Jerusalem to communicate to the leaders there that gospel which he preached among the Gentiles (Gal. 2:2), with the result that they promised to confine their ministry to Israel, recognizing *Paul* as the apostle of the Gentiles. And even *at that council*, the Circumcision apostles wrote concerning those who had gone out from them to impose their message and program upon the Gentiles:

"Forasmuch as we have heard, that CERTAIN WHICH WENT OUT FROM US have troubled you with words, subverting your souls, saying, Ye must

be circumcised, and keep the law. TO WHOM WE GAVE NO SUCH COMMANDMENT,[23] (Acts 15,24).

Thus those to whom Paul wrote at Rome could scarcely have been converts of the Circumcision believers. They had doubtless been won to Christ through those whom Paul had reached with "the gospel of the grace of God."

This leads us to recognize another important fact. We have seen from Matt. 24:14 that if the twelve had gotten their message to all the world "the end" of that dispensation would have come. This proves at the same time that Paul was *not* laboring to fulfil the "great commission" to the eleven, and that he did *not* preach the same gospel as they, for then "the end" would have come in his day, since he *says* that his message had gone to "all the world."

THE AMAZING ENERGY WITH WHICH PAUL PROCLAIMED GRACE

To the Romans the apostle writes of his commission from the ascended Lord:

"By whom we have received grace and apostleship, for obedience to the faith among ALL NATIONS, for His name" (Rom. 1:5).

In his Ephesian Epistle he writes:

"Unto me, who am less than the least of all saints, is this grace given, that I should preach among the Gentiles the unsearchable riches of Christ;

"And TO MAKE ALL MEN SEE what is the fellowship [Gr., oikonomia, dispensation] of the mystery . . ." (Eph. 3:8,9).

But while it is generally acknowledged that he was commissioned to proclaim grace to all nations, there are few who have quite realized the amazing energy with which the apostle proclaimed this message in the face of the most relentless persecution, or the wide extent of his ministry and influence.

In Pisidian Antioch "almost the whole city" came together to hear the Word of God, but the unbelieving Jews, filled with envy, contradicted and blasphemed, and it was necessary for Paul and Barnabas to turn from them to the Gentiles.

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[23] The Circumcision saints themselves still remained under the law for the time being (see Acts 21:20) but, recognizing Paul's further revelation and his commission to the Gentiles, they condemned an trouble makers those of their number who sought to impose their message and program upon the Gentiles. So did Paul (see Gal. 1:6,7).

"And the Word of the Lord was published throughout all the region.

"But the Jews stirred up the devout and honorable women, and the chief men of the city, and raised persecution against Paul and Barnabas, and expelled them out of their coasts" (Acts 13:49,50).

In Iconium, where he next preached the gospel, *"the multitude of the city was divided."*

"And when there was an assault made both of the Gentiles, and also of the Jews with their rulers, to use them despitefully, and to stone them.

"They were ware of It, and fled unto Lystra and Derbe....

"And there they preached the gospel" (Acts 14:5-7).

At Lystra the people first tried to offer sacrifices to Paul and Barnabas as gods, but this attitude changed abruptly when

". . . **there came thither certain Jews from Antioch and Iconium, who persuaded the people, and, having stoned Paul, drew [dragged] him out of the city, supposing he had been dead" (Acts 14:19).**

And then, after preaching the gospel in Derbe, and teaching many, they went right back to the cities where they had risked their lives and had suffered such persecution.

"Confirming the souls of the disciples, and exhorting them to continue in the faith ..." (Acts 14:22).

Returning to Antioch in Syria, from whence they had been sent forth, they found certain men from Judaea seeking to bring the Gentile believers under the Law of Moses, and "*Paul and Barnabas had no small dissension and disputation with them"* (Acts 15:2).

As a result of this Paul and Barnabas went up to Jerusalem to settle the matter with the leaders of the Messianic Church there. On this occasion Paul took Titus, a Greek, with him as a test case and was later able to write to the Galatians: "*Titus . . . was not compelled to be circumcised either."* And concerning those who would have had it so, he said:

"To whom we gave place by subjection, no, not for an hour, that the truth of the gospel might continue with you" (Gal. 2.5).

Think of the energy required for all this!

Next we find the apostle going forth with Silas and again it is peril, persecution and toil wherever he goes.

At Philippi he is beaten with many stripes and imprisoned. At Thessalonica *"the Jews which believed not . . . set all the city on an uproar*" (Acts 17:5) and things became so dangerous that *"the brethren immediately sent away Paul and Silas by night unto Berea"* (Ver. 10). But the unbelieving Jews from Thessalonica followed him to Berea and *"stirred up the people"* there, so that this time ". *.the brethren sent away Paul to go as it were to the sea. .* ." (Acts 17:14).

At Athens he got "the cold shoulder" and *"departed from among them*" to Corinth, where he was able to remain for a year and six months, but not without tasting much opposition and persecution.

At Ephesus he went to the synagogue "*and spake boldly for the space of three months, disputing and persuading the things concerning the kingdom of God."* Then, when *"divers were hardened, and believed not*" he *"separated the disciples"* from the unbelieving multitude and went with them to "the school of one Tyrannus," where he "*disputed daily*."

"And this continued by the space of two years; so that all they which dwelt in Asia [the province of Asia] heard the word of the Lord Jesus, both Jews and Greeks" (Acts 19:8-10).

Indeed, before Paul left Ephesus so much had been accomplished that a public bonfire was held, at which those who had been won to Christ burned heathen books amounting in value to 50,000 pieces of silver. "*So mightily grew the Word of God and prevailed"* (Acts 19:20). But this was followed by the great uproar at which Demetrius and the craftsmen who made silver shrines for Diana stirred up the unbelieving masses to such a pitch that for two hours they cried *"Great is Diana of the Ephesians."* (Ver. 34).

"And when Paul would have entered in unto the people, the disciples suffered him not" (Ver. 30).

Concerning this ministry in Asia Minor, the apostle writes to the Corinthians:

"For we would not, brethren, have you ignorant of our trouble which came to us in Asia; that WE WERE PRESSED OUT OF MEASURE, ABOVE STRENGTH, INSOMUCH THAT WE DESPAIRED EVEN OF LIFE" (II Cor. 1:8).

At Troas, on the first day of the week, Paul preached in an upper room *"until midnight"* (Acts 20:7), then *"talked a long while, even till the break of day"* (Ver. 11) and then departed again to continue his journey to Jerusalem.

"And from Miletus he sent to Ephesus, and called the elders of the church" and, exhorting them to stand fast, reminded them how he had served the Lord among them, ". . . *with many tears, and temptations, which befell me by the lying in wait of the Jews: and ... taught you publicly and from house to house"* (Vers. 17-20), adding:

"Therefore watch and remember, that BY THE SPACE OF THREE YEARS I CEASED NOT TO WARN EVERY ONE NIGHT AND DAY WITH TEARS" (Ver. 31).

Finally, having been sent from Jerusalem to Rome in chains, he was able to write to the Philippian believers:

". . . the things which happened unto me have fallen out rather unto the furtherance of the gospel;

"So that MY BONDS IN CHRIST ARE MANIFEST IN ALL THE PALACE, AND IN ALL OTHER PLACES" (Phil. 1:12, 13).

And again:

". . . The brethren which are with me greet you.

"ALL THE SAINTS SALUTE YOU, CHIEFLY THEY THAT ARE OF CAESAR'S HOUSEHOLD" (Phil. 4:21,22).

So mightily was the apostle used, even while in bonds, that his imprisonment for Christ was a subject of discussion throughout and beyond the wicked Nero's palace, and a company of believers had sprung up within the palace itself.

And all the while the apostle continued, in the face of much opposition, to do his utmost to get the truth to those without, even to those whom he had never seen, writing, for example, to the Colossians:

"FOR I WOULD THAT YE KNEW WHAT GREAT CONFLICT I HAVE FOR YOU, AND FOR THEM AT LAODICEA, AND FOR AS MANY AS HAVE NOT SEEN MY FACE IN THE FLESH" (Col. 2:1).

Thus, under Paul's ministry there did take place a world-wide proclamation of "the gospel of the grace of God," so that he could write to Timothy about the epiphany, the shining forth, of God's grace to all mankind.

THE APOSTLE DIVINELY EMPOWERED

But how, even recognizing Paul's organized efforts to send the gospel to "the regions beyond," could one man have accomplished so much? What was the source of the amazing energy that took him from one uprising into another; that urged him on and on with his proclamation of the gospel of grace, though even lacking much needed rest? How could he keep enduring stripes and imprisonments, stonings and shipwreck, long journeys with perils of every sort? How could he go on bearing weariness, pain, watchings, hunger, thirst, cold, nakedness? And all these things, in addition to "the care of all the churches," he had already suffered by the time he wrote his Second Epistle to the Corinthians (See II Cor. 11:23-28). Indeed, in his First Epistle to the Corinthians he writes:

"Even unto this present hour we both hunger, and thirst, and are naked, and are buffeted, and have no certain dwelling place" (I Cor. 4:11).

How could one man endure all this?

The answer to this question is also given to us in the inspired writings of the apostle himself. It is simply that he was *divinely empowered*, as the following passages indicate:

"FOR I WILL NOT DARE TO SPEAK OF ANY OF THOSE THINGS WHICH CHRIST HATH NOT WROUGHT BY ME. TO MAKE THE GENTILES OBEDIENT, BY WORD AND DEED" (Rom. 15:18).

"BUT BY THE GRACE OF GOD I AM WHAT I AM: AND HIS GRACE WHICH WAS BESTOWED UPON ME WAS NOT IN "IN; BUT I LABORED MORE ABUNDANTLY THAN THEY ALL, YET NOT I, BUT THE GRACE OF GOD WHICH WAS WITH ME" (I Cor. 15:10).

"FOR HE THAT WROUGHT EFFECTUALLY IN PETER TO THE APOSTLESHIP OF THE CIRCUMCISION, THE SAME WAS MIGHTY IN ME TOWARD THE GENTILES" (Gal. 2:8).

"Whereunto I also labor, STRIVING ACCORDING TO HIS WORKING, WHICH WORKETH IN ME MIGHTILY" (Col. 1:29).

"At my first answer [before Nero] no man stood with me, but all men forsook me: I pray God that It may not be laid to their charge.

"NOTWITHSTANDING THE LORD STOOD WITH ME, AND STRENGTHENED ME; THAT BY ME THE PREACHING MIGHT BE FULLY KNOWN, AND THAT ALL THE GENTILES MIGHT HEAR: and I was delivered out of the mouth of the lion" (II Tim. 4:16,17).

Thus it was that the apostle could write about *"the epiphany of grace,"* the shining forth of grace "*to all mankind."*

THE LIGHT DIMMED

But alas how the light has since been dimmed! How lightly men have esteemed the infinite grace of God! Indeed, it was during the apostle's own ministry that he had to write to the Galatians:

"I MARVEL THAT YE ARE SO SOON REMOVED FROM HIM THAT CALLED YOU INTO THE GRACE OF CHRIST UNTO ANOTHER GOSPEL" (Gal. 1:6).

For this Christendom has called the Galatian believers fickle, and commentators have quoted the statements of certain Roman rulers to prove that the Gauls were by nature changeable. We believe, however, that politicians and statesmen in any age, including our own, could be cited to prove that the public is fickle! And the Apostle Paul would certainly have to say with respect to the Church as a whole, historically: *"I marvel that ye are so soon removed from him that called you into the grace of Christ unto another gospel."*

Galatians 1:6 is not only the word of Paul to the Galatians but also the Word of God to the Church as a whole, for how soon the Church departed from the great revelation of the glorified Christ through Paul! This declension *began*, as we say, during Paul's own lifetime. One church after another was affected by it. We have seen how through his ministry "all they which dwelt in Asia heard the word of the Lord Jesus," but it was not many years before the apostle had to write to Timothy:

"THIS THOU KNOWEST THAT ALL THEY WHICH ARE IN ASIA BE TURNED AWAY FROM ME ... " (II Tim. 1:15).

From the writings of the early-century fathers which still exist it is evident that rather than recognizing the distinctive character of Paul's message, they had it all confused with the kingdom message proclaimed by John the Baptist, Christ and the twelve, even to requiring water baptism for the remission of sins.

And this declension went on apace until the dark ages, when Rome held sway and a mixture of Christianity, Judaism and heathen idolatry prevailed. Later the Church *began* to emerge from the darkness and superstition of Romanism as Luther, Zwingli, Calvin and others were used to recover Pauline truth. And, thank God, still greater advances were made under such men as Darby and Scofield. But much, very much, still remains to be done. Those who are now laboring to carry out the commission of the glorified Lord to *us* (II Cor.

5:14-21), who desire to recover and make known the blessed message of grace and glory, will have to pray and toil and sacrifice as never before to make any impression upon the indifferent masses - including carnal Christians. Those who know the truth but maintain a discreet silence because they fear men or "love the praise of men," yes, and those who fail to proclaim the *whole* truth for "diplomacy's sake" - all these will have to cast aside their selfish interests if the grace of God is to shine forth with any degree of brightness again.

OUR RESPONSIBILITY TO RELIGHT THE TORCH

We know, of course, that the millennium will be brought in *by the return of Christ,* not by the efforts of men. But we have not been discussing the millennium. We have been discussing God's revealed program for "this present evil age," the time of Christ's rejection and absence, and it is God's command that we make the message of His grace known to all men. The fact that "evil men and seducers shall wax worse and worse" does not relieve us of this responsibility. However the darkness may deepen, we are to "shine as lights in the world; *holding forth the word of life"* (Phil. 2:15,16).

Once God's grace was made to shine forth to all mankind in spite of the most bitter and Satanic opposition. Then the torch began to flicker until the world was plunged into the Dark Ages and scarcely a spark remained. Then, after centuries, it was lit again and began to burn somewhat more brightly. But still it must be made to blaze afar.

In these critical times shall we not make it *our one passion* to *know* God's Word, rightly divided, and to *make it known* to others, until the grace of God shines forth again as a blazing torch? Shall we not, must we not, put aside *every* other consideration and say with Paul:

"BUT AS WE [ARE] ALLOWED OF GOD TO BE PUT IN TRUST WITH THE GOSPEL, EVEN SO WE SPEAK; NOT AS PLEASING MEN, BUT GOD, WHICH TRIETH OUR HEARTS" (I Thes. 2:4).

Soon enough our Lord will appear in glory and our work will be done. *Now* He would have His *grace* appear *through us.* Whatever the opposition of Satan, then, and however deceitful its character, let us say with the apostle of grace:

"BUT NONE OF THESE THINGS MOVE ME, NEITHER COUNT I MY LIFE DEAR UNTO MYSELF, SO THAT I MIGHT FINISH MY COURSE WITH JOY, AND THE MINISTRY WHICH I HAVE RECEIVED OF THE LORD JESUS, TO TESTIFY THE GOSPEL OF THE GRACE OF GOD" (Acts 20:24).

If we do this we shall also be able to say with him, when we come to the end of the way:

"I HAVE FOUGHT A GOOD FIGHT, I HAVE FINISHED MY COURSE, I HAVE KEPT THE FAITH:

"HENCEFORTH THERE IS LAID UP FOR ME A CROWN..." (II Tim. 4:7,8).

Chapter XIII

LET'S TAKE INVENTORY

At the close of the year - at least of the fiscal year - most business concerns take inventory. This is not only done for tax purposes; it is done also to determine which items have been selling well, which should be discontinued, which should be "pushed."

This has its analogy in our ministry of the Word, for in a sense we believers too are "salesmen," seeking to convince men that they need what we have to offer.[24]

Let us then take inventory.

STOCK ON HAND

The stock in which we have invested is nothing less than the Word of God. As we look over the individual items, there are some which have always been popular, at least with Bible-believing Christians. Others, however, are frankly not moving as well as they should. Among these, three stand out:

1. The truth about Paul's distinctive apostleship.

2. The truth about the so-called "great commission."

3. The truth about water baptism.

As we look into the *reason* why these items are not moving as they should, one thing stands out: the *cost.*

This, we believe, is essentially what brought the new evangelicalism into existence. Fundamentalist leaders, their positions and pride at stake, rejected their only hope for theological unity. They resisted "the preaching of Jesus Christ *according to the revelation of the mystery,"* God's great message of unadulterated grace, with its "*one body*" and "*one baptism*." This because their denominational systems were based on the unscriptural theory that the present dispensation of grace began with Peter and the eleven under the so-called "great commission," rather than later with Paul, the chief of sinners saved by grace.

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[24] See God's Word to the Buyers In Prov. 23:23.

Thus the confusion deepened and divisions were multiplied, resulting in the emergence of the new evangelicalism, which has, for some two decades, promoted union by compromise, a poor substitute indeed for the unity described in Eph. 4:4-6.

It does indeed cost to believe and stand for any of the three important truths listed above. Religious denominationalism as a whole is bitterly opposed to even discussing these subjects. Often positions and salaries are involved. Surely those who "buy" these truths and refuse to sell out after buying them cannot expect to be popular with the religious hierarchy or with the religious masses who follow them.

Shall we then discontinue these items and offer only the more popular ones? No, indeed! We should rather "push" these items, advertising and promoting them more widely than ever. This for several reasons:

1. These items are well worth the price tags attached.

2. Often they do not "sell" simply because we have not - or have not been able to - inform the general public about them. Religious leaders have warned their hearers that these precious truths are heresies and have kept many from even being willing to consider what the *Bible* says about them. Most of these leaders do not really study and teach the Bible; they only promote their denominational creed - or worse, promote the unscriptural, Christ-denying liberalism which has wrought such havoc in the past fifty years.

3. The Owner of the "store" and our Employer, God Himself, has given distinct orders that these items be "pushed."

As we "take inventory," then, let us consider how the above three items are indeed of value to the general public, how amply they are worth the cost, and how we might better promote them.

PAUL'S DISTINCTIVE APOSTLESHIP

The Apostle Paul surely did not write from human pride, but by divine inspiration, when he said:

"For I speak to you Gentiles, Inasmuch as I AM THE APOSTLE OF THE GENTILES; I magnify mine office" (Rom. 11:13).

Indeed, in Gal. 2:2-9 we read that when Paul went up to the leaders at Jerusalem to communicate to them "that gospel which I preach among the Gentiles" (Ver. 2), they "saw" (Ver. 7) and "perceived" (Ver. 9) that God had indeed entrusted a new revelation to him, and solemnly, publicly, officially gave

him "the right hand of fellowship" (Ver. 9), acknowledging him as God's new apostle to the nations and agreeing to confine their own ministry henceforth to Israel.

What a pity that so many religious leaders do not yet "see" or "perceive" this! If they were but willing to consider and accept this one important Scriptural fact much of the theological confusion prevailing in the Church would be dispelled.

Surely this item in our inventory should be widely advertised and promoted and we have many, many passages of Scripture to use as "promotional material" in our efforts to make it known.

An understanding of Paul's distinctive position as God's appointed apostle for the present dispensation of grace will clear up many related questions regarding the Holy Spirit's operation, miraculous signs, the return of Christ, etc. This item on our stock shelves is indeed a truth we dare not discard or discount.

THE "GREAT COMMISSION" QUESTION

The "great commission" which our Lord gave to His apostles while still on earth has been dealt with most unfairly, even by Bible-believing fundamentalists, not to mention the neo-evangelicals and the liberals**.**

Pastors who are supposed to teach the Bible will bring "devotional" messages on the *"Go ye"* and "*lo, I am with you*" of Matt. 28:19,20, or on the "*all the world*" and "*every creature*" of Mark 16:15, or on the "*ye are witnesses"* of Luke 24:48, or on the "ye *shall receive power"* of Acts 1:8, but they do not expound these passages as a whole; they do not explain what the Lord was actually commanding the apostles to do, and they are very careful *not* to bring in St. John's record of the same commission, where our Lord says: *"Whose soever sins ye remit, they are remitted unto them; and whose soever sins ye retain they are retained*" (John 20:23).

This so-called "great commission" speaks of our Lord's "power" (authority) on earth as well as in heaven and commands obedience to the law of Moses (Matt. 28:18-20 cf. 23:1-3); it requires baptism for salvation and promises that miraculous signs *"shall* follow them that believe" (Mark 16:15-18); it directs that "repentance and remission of sins should be preached ... among all nations, *beginning at Jerusalem*" (Luke 24:46,47); it gives human beings (soon to be filled with the Holy Spirit - Acts 2:4) the authority to remit sins (John 20:23) ; it promises the twelve all the "power" that they exhibited in the early chapters of Acts (Acts 1:8 cf. Chapters 1-5).

But this same commission has not one word to say about salvation by grace through faith, on the basis of Christ's shed blood; it has not one word to say about our "one baptism" into Christ or about our position and blessings in the heavenlies in Christ. It does not declare that now *"there is no difference between the Jew and the Greek"* since *"the same Lord over all is rich unto all that call upon Him*," so that *"whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved";* much less does it say anything about the reconciliation of Jews and Gentiles to God in one body by the cross. NONE of this was proclaimed until our risen, glorified Lord entrusted the greatest commission of all to that *other* apostle: Paul.

Under *his* "great commission" we learn about "*redemption through [Christ's] blood, the forgiveness of sins ACCORDING TO THE RICHES OF HIS GRACE"* (Eph. 1:7), about *salvation by grace APART FROM THE LAW AND APART FROM WORKS* (Rom. 3:20,21; 4:5; Eph. 2:8-10; Tit. 3:5, *et al*), about our blessed oneness with Christ, effected by a *SUPERNATURAL BAPTISM* (Rom. 6:3; Col. 2:10-12), about our oneness with each other, effected by that same *DIVINE BAPTISM* (I Cor. 12:13). Here we learn that believing Jews and Gentiles are "*reconciled unto God in one Body by the cross"* (Eph. 2:16). It is under this commission that those who believe are seated with Christ and *blessed with* "*all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ"* (Eph. 1:3; 2:5,6).

Should we not keep these spiritual items on our "shelves" whatever the cost and advertise and promote them vigorously? Should we not show to interested "buyers" the value of these precious truths in comparison with those "advertised and sold" under the so-called "great commission"? Does it bother the "buyer" that the *word* "commission" is not found in the passages cited above? Then show him II Cor. 5:14-21, where the word is used twice in connection with our God-given ministry for our day.

THE BAPTISM QUESTION

Under the so-called "great commission," the commission which our Lord gave to His apostles while still on earth, water baptism was required for the remission of sins. Those who deny this have several clear passages of holy writ to contend with.

In Mark's record of this commission our Lord is distinctly quoted as saying:

"He that belleveth AND IS BAPTIZED shall be saved; but he that belleveth not[25] shall be damned" (Mark 16:16).

[25] Whether or not baptized.

Those, in turn, who interpret this to mean that those who are saved should *then* be baptized should repent of their perversion of Scripture. Peter, one of those to whom this commission was first given and who then was filled with the Holy Spirit, must have known how to interpret our Lord's words-and he interpreted them to mean exactly what they say: "He that believeth *and is baptized* shall be saved." Read carefully his Spirit-inspired injunction to his convicted hearers at Pentecost:

“Then Peter said unto them, Repent, and be baptized every one of you in the name of Jesus Christ FOR THE REMISSION OF SINS, and ye shall receive the gift of the Holy Ghost" (Acts 2:38).

If this be not enough, it should be remembered that as late as the conversion of Saul of Tarsus, God sent Ananias, "a devout man according to the law, having a good report among all the Jews which dwelt there" to instruct Paul:

"**Arise and be baptized, and wash away thy sins, calling on the name of the Lord" (Acts 22:16).**

It is true, of course, that physical water cannot wash away moral sins, but this passage shows nevertheless that water baptism was still required for the washing away of sins. It was a typical cleansing, required by God for salvation.

What is most significant in all this is the clear implication that God was continuing His program begun with John the Baptist, at least where baptism and the remission of sins was concerned. In Mark 1:4 we are distinctly told:

"John did baptize in the wilderness and preach the baptism of repentance FOR THE REMISSION OF SINS."

If our religious leaders change the meaning of Mark 16:16 and Acts 2:38, should they not be consistent and make the same change here? And then what will they do with Luke 7:30, which says:

"But the Pharisees and lawyers rejected the counsel of God against themselves, being not baptized of him."

What confusion results when we deny or seek to alter the plain Word of God. If anything is clear from the volume of Scripture on this point it is that water baptism was required for the remission of sins from John the Baptist through Pentecost. And it is fully as clear that water baptism now is *not* required for the remission of sins, indeed, that it has now been abolished and replaced by a divine baptism. Hear God's Word on the subject:

"NOT BY WORKS OF RIGHTEOUSNESS WHICH WE HAVE DONE, BUT ACCORDING TO HIS MERCY HE SAVED US, BY THE WASHING OF REGENERATION AND THE RENEWING OF THE HOLY GHOST" (Tit. 3:5).

"Know ye not that so many of us as were BAPTIZED INTO JESUS CHRIST were BAPTIZED INTO HIS DEATH?" (Rom. 6:3).

Surely a water ceremony could not bury us into the death of Christ. It was when we recognized that His death was actually our death, the penalty for *our* sins, that we were "baptized into Jesus Christ," and made one with Him. This is why Col. 2:12 declares that this baptism is effected by "the operation of God." This under the heading: "Ye are complete *in Him*" (Ver. 10).

And being baptized into Christ, we are also baptized into His Body, made one with all its members because we are one with Christ.

"FOR BY ONE SPIRIT ARE WE ALL BAPTIZED INTO ONE BODY, whether we be Jews or Gentiles, whether we be bond or free; and have been all made to drink Into one Spirit" (I Cor. 12:13).

What a glorious truth is this, and abundant “promotional material" has been given to us in God's Word to help us "sell" this item!

SALESMEN AND SOLDIERS

It is true indeed that salvation is bestowed by grace and received through faith - entirely apart from works, religious or otherwise. But it is equally true that it *costs* to embrace the truth and costs even more to stand for it, rather than selling out. This is why Proverbs 23:23 exhorts us to "*Buy the truth and sell it not.*" In *this* sense we are not to sell the truth. Yet in another sense we are salesmen of the truth, urging men to buy it.

As we do this we find that there are those who would actually seek to hinder men from buying the truth. Yet it is not primarily they who oppose our efforts, but Satan and his hosts.

"For we wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world [age], against spiritual wickedness [wicked spirits] in high places" (Eph. 6:12).

This is why God's salesmen must also be *"good soldiers of Jesus Christ"* (II Tim. 2:3). We must make the glorious message known *despite the opposition*. We must "put on the whole armor of God" and meet our adversaries with "the Sword of the Spirit, which is the Word of God" (Eph. 6:11,17). When they would shut our mouths we must pray for ourselves and each other:

"... that utterance may be given unto me, THAT I MAY OPEN MY MOUTH BOLDLY, to make known the mystery of the gospel.[26]

". . . THAT THEREIN I MAY SPEAK BOLDLY, AS I OUGHT TO SPEAK" (Eph. 6:19,20).

This, by the grace of God, is our prayer and our resolve.

[26] The message for the dispensation of grace, committed to Paul by glorified Lord (Eph. 3:1-3; Col. 1:25-28).

Chapter XIV

FIDELITY, APOSTASY AND INDECISION

"And Elijah came unto all the people, and said, How long halt ye between two opinions? If the Lord be God, follow Him: but if Baal, then follow him. And the people answered him not a word."

- I Kings 18:21.

In the record of Elijah's confrontation with Israel and his contest with the prophets of Baal, we have a valuable lesson on fidelity, apostasy and indecision.

From James 5:17 we learn that Elijah was "subject to like passions as we are." He was no stranger to fear, and the temptation to be accepted by the religious "organization" and the ruling power was as great an attraction to him as to many of his kinsmen. But his fidelity to God wrought in his heart a deep concern over the growing foothold that Baal worship was gaining in Israel.

He was grieved that King Ahab should allow the wicked Jezebel to gradually substitute the worship of Baal for that of Jehovah - so grieved, that "he prayed earnestly that it might not rain," that God might speak to His people by sending a drought upon the land.

The Lord answered Elijah's prayer by sending *him* to Ahab with the message:

"As the Lord God of Israel liveth, before whom I stand, them shall not be dew nor rain these years, but according to my word" (I Kings 17:1).

And so it came to pass, for, as James puts it*: "It rained not on the earth by the space of three years and six months"* (James 5:17).

By this time the land had been devastated. All was parched and barren. There were no crops, hence no farm laborers to be seen anywhere. The cattle were dying on every hand. Great cracks in the earth testified to the seriousness of the drought, and the king himself was finally obliged to search for water to save his own horses and mules. It was as if Jehovah had burnt the land up in His wrath. And for all this Elijah was blamed and forced to hide for his life. He was considered to be the one who had "troubled Israel" (I Kings 18:17).

But Elijah could not hide forever. As abruptly as he had disappeared from sight, so abruptly did he reappear. After three and a half years of withering drought, God commanded him: *"Go, show thyself unto Ahab*" (I Kings 18:1).

The rest of the story is well known: how Ahab gathered the children of Israel together at Mt. Carmel, and how Elijah publicly challenged the prophets of Baal before them; how he gave the Baalites every advantage in the contest and, as Jehovah's prophet, exposed the impotence of this pagan god, demonstrating that Jehovah, Israel's God, was indeed the true and only God.

If the people had expected Elijah to go into a long harangue about the evils of apostasy they were mistaken indeed. *They* knew its evils. Therefore his words were brief and to the point:

"How long halt ye between two opinions? If the Lord be God, follow Him; but if Baal, then follow him" (Ver. 21).

The words "How long?" lie at the heart of the prophet's challenge, and the divine comment that *"the people answered him not a word,"* testifies to their sense of guilt. Together they show how apostasy takes root gradually. It was when Ahab first showed a friendly attitude toward Baal worship that men of God in Israel should have spoken out against it, but for the most part they counted the cost, "halted between two opinions" and - did nothing. At length it became necessary for Elijah to appear personally before the king and denounce his apostasy. This he did courageously in the name of *"Jehovah God ... before whom I stand."* Why should one who daily lived in the presence of God fear to appear before an apostate king?

But by this time the worship of Baal had become so deeply entrenched in Israel that those who refused, or rightly feared, to worship Baal were driven underground - so far underground that Elijah did not even realize that they existed (I Kings 18:22; 19:10,18). And now after three and a half years of severe divine discipline the multitudes in Israel were still halting between two opinions,[27] paying homage to *both* Jehovah and Baal.

Thus does indecision in spiritual matters breed apostasy. The responsibility for Israel's appalling condition was due not only to Jezebel's aggressiveness and Ahab's moral and spiritual weakness; it was due in large part to the indifference of *the people themselves.* It was not Ahab alone, nor the leaders of Israel, whom Elijah addressed in his challenge. It was *the people* he reproved for failing to stand up and be counted from the time that Baal worship was first introduced.

What a lesson to us who live in *"this present evil age*," when Satan appears as *"an angel of light"* and his ministers as *"ministers of righteousness!" Now* more than ever apostasy enters *subtly, gradually*, and it may be concluded that

[27] Lit.. limping on two hips, i.e., standing first on one foot, then on the other.

those who "halt between two opinions" when it first gets its foot into the door will probably still be temporizing when it becomes entrenched. The positions, financial gain and other temporal considerations that kept them from taking a stand in the beginning will by then have gotten them more deeply involved.

How important, then, are the exhortations so prominent in the writings and sayings of Paul, to stand against any form of apostasy *when it first appears*! He says: *"Take heed . . . watch"* (Acts 20:28,31), *"Ye are the temple of the living God ... Wherefore ... TOUCH NOT the unclean thing"* (II Cor. 6:16-18).

It is a human failure to wish to be friendly to "both sides" where spiritual conflict is concerned. But God says: *"How long halt ye between two opinions?" - "Who is on the Lord's side?" - "Choose* ye" - *"He that is not with Me is against Me."*

WHERE DO YOU STAND?

"And It came to pass, when Joshua was by Jericho, that he lifted up his eyes and looked and, behold, there stood a man over against him with his sword drawn in his hand,. And Joshua went unto him, and said unto him. Art thou for us, or for our adversaries? And he said, Nay; but as captain of the host of the Lord am I now come. And Joshua fell on his face to the earth, and did worship, and said unto him, What saith my Lord unto his servant?"

- Josh. 5:13,24.

God had appointed Joshua to lead the people of Israel into the land of Canaan. It was just before the battle of Jericho that the great leader looked up to see a man with a drawn sword facing him. His sudden appearance must have startled Joshua, but he showed no trace of fear - not Joshua!

Advancing toward the man Joshua demanded: "Art thou for us or for our adversaries?" No wonder the answer brought him to his knees! He had been standing face to face with the captain of the Lord's hosts, no doubt Michael, the angelic prince of Israel (See Dan. 10:21 and 12:1).

The question was not, whose side was the angel of God on, but whose side was Joshua on! Was he himself in harmony with God's will?

There is an important lesson for us here. In the constant battle over truth and error there is a tendency for Christians to demand of other Christians: "Whose side are you on? Are you for us or for our adversaries?"

If this is as far as we have gotten in our service for the Lord we still have much to learn, for the great question is not: "Are *you* on *my* side?" but "Am *I* on *God's* side?"

God's truth will prevail. His purposes will be carried out, and even though we might be on the side of the most powerful and influential of men, we will surely be driven to defeat if we are not in harmony with God's Word and Will.

Shall we not all fall on our faces with Joshua then, and say: *"What saith my Lord unto His servant?"*